Equity Audit and Action Plan

PROPOSAL RESPONSE

In Response to RFP No. 25-600
September 12, 2023 | 2:00 PM (ET)

Submitted to:
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November 28, 2023

Mr. Fred Christopher
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RE: RFP No. 25-600 Comprehensive Equity Audit

Dear Mr. Christopher:

As the United States' population continues to diversify, it is increasingly imperative that educational institutions acknowledge the existence of inequities and create deliberate avenues for all students to succeed. The DeKalb County School District (DCSD) understands this challenge. To advance this commitment, DCSD has called for an equity assessment to review opportunities and outcomes and develop a comprehensive, community-driven plan to advance equity in six key areas: instructional and programmatic equity; equitable organizational leadership; equitable resource distribution; equitable collaboration and support for parents, families, and the community; equitable professional learning and growth; and equitable school climate.

The American Institutes for Research® (AIR®) applies the best behavioral and social science research, evaluation, and technical assistance toward improving people's lives—to ensure that all people have access to the resources they need. This equity-driven mission is our foundation. It shapes the work we do, informs our relationships with clients and partners, and brings an emphasis on diversity and inclusion to our own offices. AIR has a wealth of knowledge and success conducting equity assessments. We have worked extensively with districts of all sizes and demographics, including districts in Georgia and those with student and community populations comparable to DCSD's. While many districts grapple with similar questions and challenges regarding equity, our experience has taught us that there is no one-size-fits-all solution. Successfully addressing equity issues requires a deep understanding of the district, community, historical context, and root causes of educational disparities and an ability to leverage the community's values and strengths in pursuit of equity.

Presented in this proposal is AIR's unique approach to the collaborative development and implementation of an equity audit and action plan. This approach combines AIR's strong research foundation with our proprietary co-interpretation℠ and innovative implementation tools. Our approach has proven effective for districts around the country because it integrates diverse stakeholder perspectives and provides insights and recommendations that are tailored to local contexts—key for generating the buy-in necessary to create equitable educational experiences for all students and families.

Please direct contractual questions about this proposal to Rachel Forbes, contracts specialist, at 202-403-6308 or AIRproposals@air.org. For technical questions, please contact Orrin Murray, PhD, at omurray@air.org.

Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,

Kandace Jones
Vice President
Education Systems & Policy

Executive Summary

The American Institutes for Research® (AIR®) is pleased to present a comprehensive, tailored, and community-engaged approach to the request for proposal (No. 25-600) of DeKalb County School District (DCSD) for an equity audit and action plan (EAAP). AIR's four-stage model includes (a) collaborative planning with a district-led EAAP steering committee; (b) rigorous collection and analysis of existing and new quantitative and qualitative data, including surveys, interviews, and focus groups with students, staff, parents/caregivers, and district leadership; (c) AIR's proprietary co-interpretation℠ process for collaboratively identifying key findings and root causes of inequities; and (d) a final report of findings and a community-informed, multiyear strategic equity action plan focused on establishing systems for promoting equity through recommended policies and practices.

AIR recognizes DCSD's commitment to using the tools necessary to support its journey toward ensuring every student's success. By applying equity by design to ensure targeted approaches for advancing universal access and system equity, AIR shares DCSD's core beliefs of identifying and addressing barriers to inclusive and equitable practices and outcomes for students. AIR also recognizes that systemic change is necessary to provide high-quality, relevant, and differentiated resources matched to each school's needs and strengths, as documented in the district's mission. AIR acknowledges that the equity assessment will serve an important role in expanding this work, particularly through an action plan aligned with the district's mission to partner with families and communities to provide inclusive and fair learning experiences that support the whole child. Given the district's goals to address student achievement (increasing the percentage of students demonstrating readiness in various subject areas) and commitment to student social-emotional wellbeing and sense of belonging (through increasing the number of staff training in mental health awareness), AIR is committed to collaborating with DCSD leadership and other district partners to examine the district's current policies and practices and providing recommendations for promoting systemic equity as described in the DCSD Core Beliefs.

AIR has a wealth of experience and success conducting equity assessments and work of a scope comparable to that of the proposed project with districts across the United States. These include two districts in the southern United States (e.g., Houston Independent School District) and others of a similar demographic composition, including majority-minority communities with large populations of Latino/Latina students and/or students from socioeconomically disadvantaged backgrounds. In the pages that follow, we highlight 16 of these projects, provide references for three clients who can speak to our services and success, and include three examples of final reports and equity action plans that we have created for past clients. Through this work, we have fine-tuned a rigorous and comprehensive equity assessment process that leverages principles of cultural and linguistic competence to include diverse community members and elevate the experiences of those who suffer the greatest marginalization within educational systems. This process includes a commitment to transparent communication with clients and stakeholders and a tried-and-true strategy for ensuring that all members of the community are informed about the goals, activities, and findings of equity assessments and have opportunities to shape the direction of the work in ways that best meet the community's needs. We find that this approach to engaging the community mitigates resistance and positions stakeholders to both understand and accept the findings of equity assessments as valid, even those that may be distressing.

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AIR does not conceptualize equity assessments as something that we "do to" a community, but rather as a collaborative process that we facilitate alongside communities. We bring experience, strategies, and tools for engaging stakeholders in collaborative reflection concerning where a district stands in terms of equity and where it wants to be. Once we have arrived at a set of findings, we develop community-informed and evidence-backed strategies for advancing equity, and we create structures to ensure that districts can continue to prioritize and monitor equity well into the future. Our approach works because it brings together a rigorous evidence base with the power of local voices and insight to generate solutions that are tailored to districts' needs, strengths, priorities, and values.

Professional Qualifications

The American Institutes for Research (AIR) is one of the world's leading behavioral and social science research, evaluation, and technical assistance institutions and a national leader in teaching and learning improvement. Our dedicated staff provide research, assessment, evaluation, and technical assistance to ensure that all students, particularly those facing historical disadvantages and systemic exclusion, have access to a high-quality, effective education. For more than 75 years, AIR has applied rigorous research to the most vexing social challenges in health, education, and the workforce in the United States and across the globe. With a diverse staff of more than 1,700, we bring together interdisciplinary teams to provide comprehensive and targeted services, and we tailor every engagement to client needs and expectations.

AIR is uniquely qualified to deliver an equity audit and action plan (EAAP). First, AIR has vast experience conducting collaborative EAAPs of the type requested by the DeKalb County School District (DCSD) with clients across the country; many are described in this proposal. Second, consistent with our mission "to generate and use rigorous evidence that contributes to a better, more equitable world," AIR holds a robust portfolio of work on educational equity across the United States. We consider equity to be the primary goal and driver of our work in education; throughout the following pages, we describe a range of equity-focused projects we have conducted that span diverse aspects of education. We have examined academic achievement, discipline practices, access to courses, instructional materials and practices in classrooms, funding and per-pupil expenditures, access to effective teachers, avenues for diversifying the workforce, mentoring and induction practices, and related issues. Thus, our team brings both theoretical and practical expertise to the issues facing DCSD and many other districts around the country.

AIR offers DCSD an EAAP approach guided by the belief that educational equity is realized when all stakeholders work together, intentionally and systematically, to identify inequities, explore their root causes, and develop actionable solutions that produce measurable results. Our experience working in such districts, including those in Georgia and other majority-minority communities, has allowed us to fine-tune a process that delivers results for clients looking to move the needle on equity. Our viewpoint on equity and how to bring about systemic equity includes the following approaches and principles:

- **AIR's participatory, client-centered approach ensures that our services and solutions are responsive to each client's needs, challenges, strengths, and priorities.** AIR staff have a wealth of expertise in the science of systems change, educational equity, community

engagement, and adult learning. At the same time, we know that every client is different. The successful application of evidence-based approaches necessitates understanding the local context. From the start of every project, AIR teams engage in collaborative planning with clients and strategically chosen stakeholders to ensure that local voices inform the direction and scope of our work.

- **AIR uses culturally and linguistically competent approaches to engage diverse stakeholders and elevate the needs of communities that experience the greatest marginalization.** To advance equity, districts need to hear from the communities that are most in need of systemic educational change. However, many individuals from these communities regard equity initiatives with skepticism or distrust due to a long history of being overlooked, dismissed, or treated unfairly in educational contexts. AIR staff take particular care when engaging community members from historically marginalized groups. Our community engagement, research, and technical assistance strategies are rooted in AIR's Culturally and Linguistically Appropriate Standards for Projects, Research, and Operations (CLAS PRO), which provide guiding principles for effectively integrating cultural and linguistic competence into all aspects of our work internally and with clients and their stakeholders.
- **AIR uses diverse strategies to deliver information in multiple ways to facilitate shared meaning making about the state of educational equity in a district.** When developing communications plans, we consider not only who needs to be reached and by what avenues, but also what existing knowledge they bring to the table and how issues of equity connect to their experiences and motivations. By sharing information in timely, relevant, and accessible ways (e.g., infographics in multiple languages, community forums), we ensure that all community members can participate in collective sensemaking around equity audit data and contribute to the creation of solutions.
- **By combining transparent communication with rigorous analyses of equity-related issues, AIR ensures that diverse constituents trust the process and results of educational equity work and find the proposed solutions appropriate and meaningful.** Issues at the heart of educational equity are sensitive, personal, and complex. Stakeholders must have confidence in the underlying motivation, process, and conclusions drawn from equity audits in order for solutions to take hold. Our participatory and inclusive approach to project development and implementation allows clients and their diverse stakeholders to see their own experiences reflected in our findings, which in turn engenders confidence.
- **AIR's experienced research and technical assistance staff support clients in putting their equity commitments into action.** As DCSD understands well, equity commitments are not sufficient to create equitable outcomes; districts must take action to address the root causes of educational inequities. AIR researchers bring a wealth of experience developing, assessing, implementing, and monitoring strategies to advance equity. AIR technical assistance consultants use supportive and effective coaching strategies to help clients achieve their goals through continuous improvement. This work has included a focus across each of DCSD's six key areas: instructional and programmatic equity; equitable organizational leadership; equitable resource distribution; equitable collaboration and support for parents, families, and the community; equitable professional learning and growth; and equitable school climate.

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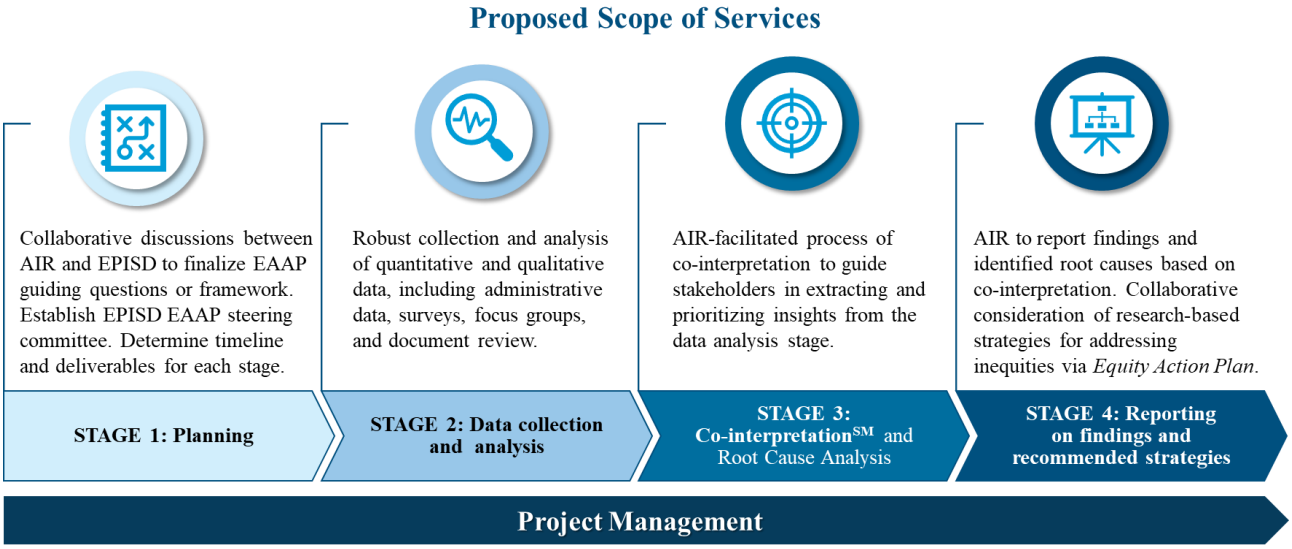
Project Approach and Implementation

Overview of EAAP Process

In this section, we detail our preferred methodology, which leverages AIR's expertise and commitment to educational equity, is grounded in research (e.g., Brown, 2010; Darling-Hammond, 2000; Goddard et al., 2017; Tieg & Nilsen, 2022), and has been successful in other districts. Using a robust mixed-methods approach, AIR brings both quantitative and qualitative data to bear on in-depth examinations of student, staff, and family experiences. As presented in Exhibit 1 our methodology consists of four stages: planning, data collection and analysis, co-interpretation, reporting on findings and recommended strategies, and implementation assistance. Throughout all stages, we leverage a collaborative approach to the planning, management, and execution of EAAP activities. In the following sections, we describe how we propose to apply this approach and methodology in service of an EAAP conducted with DCSD.

Exhibit 1. AIR's Evidence-Based Approach to Equity audits and Action Plans



Note. AIR = American Institutes for Research; EAAP = equity audit and action plan; DCSD = DeKalb County School District; READI = Resource Deficiencies, Educator Supports, Accountability Requirements, Disparities in Working Conditions, Implementation Capacity of Staff

Stage 1: Planning

AIR will work collaboratively with DCSD from the beginning to plan the EAAP and ensure the project design and deliverables meet the district's needs. During this stage, AIR and DCSD will finalize the district's guiding questions to identify key equity indicators in each of the focal areas: (a) instructional and programmatic equity; (b) equitable organizational leadership; (c) equitable resource distribution; (d) equitable collaboration and support for parents, families, and communities; (e) equitable professional learning and growth; and (f) equitable school climate. Together, we will establish the project timeline and deliverables, including DCSD's role

in assisting data collection efforts (e.g., survey administration to populations of interest). The planning stage will include the following activities:

- finalizing the guiding questions for each of the EAAP focal areas to identify key outcomes for analysis;
- reviewing materials that articulate DCSD's vision for its students and its commitment to equity—particularly the *Core Beliefs* and existing materials designed to capture progress toward system goals, including recommendations from a district document analysis and the most recent demographic and facilities studies;
- agreeing on timelines, procedures, and data to be collected for the EAAP, including efficiently administering surveys to populations of interest (e.g., students, parents or caregivers, DCSD staff);
- developing an EAAP steering committee comprised of DCSD administrators, staff, members from the school Board, students, and other key community members who will lead the EAAP in partnership with AIR; and
- identifying key methods of communication with the DCSD community to ensure transparency and inclusivity (e.g., infographics in multiple languages; recruiting students, families, and teachers for data collection activities).

Addressing equity issues across a diverse community can be challenging due to concerns about trust and transparency. AIR has found that careful co-planning and the transparency of data collection and analysis result in better community buy-in of EAAP findings. When we work carefully with clients to collect data that address the guiding questions, we find that clients and their communities accept even the most distressing findings and identified inequities as valid and reliable information. Furthermore, by collaboratively deploying key communications, we create a *no-surprises* situation for staff and community members not directly involved in the EAAP. By keeping all community members apprised of the work as it develops and by clearly communicating opportunities for participation, the steering committee will ensure that the EAAP remains rooted in community perspectives and that the district is well equipped to communicate shared conclusions about the EAAP findings and actions.

Stage 2: Data Collection and Analysis

We will use a mixed-methods research design to address the EAAP guiding questions identified in Stage 1 and to develop a clear picture of both equity-related strengths and gaps across the six key areas of interest to DCSD. AIR will align its data collection and analyses with the guiding questions to ensure that the EAAP advances the district's understanding of equity in ways that are meaningful, actionable, and aligned with district priorities. AIR will receive Institutional Review Board approval for all data collection, analysis, and reporting activities and will follow AIR's security protocols to ensure the protection and confidentiality of individual identities and responses. A data sharing agreement developed during the planning stage will ensure AIR and DCSD have a shared understanding of which data will be requested, how they will be used, and how anonymity or confidentiality will be maintained throughout analysis and reporting.

Collection of Existing Data

For each question, AIR will request relevant existing data from DCSD, including student administrative data (e.g., demographic information, enrollment, performance, disciplinary

engagement); staff demographic and performance data (e.g., race/ethnicity, gender, certification, educational attainment, years of experience, years in the district, performance reviews); financial data (e.g., school-level funding for instructional and extracurricular programming); and documentation of equity-related practices, policies, and initiatives (e.g., professional learning opportunities, family and community engagement strategies, student and employee handbooks, student support systems) as well as other practices that are essential to the district's work. Our data collection approach will be designed to minimize the burden on the district's data team and maximize the utility of available data. We will only request data that are pertinent to the EAAP guiding questions, and our experienced team is prepared to clean and merge data as needed for analyses. Although some of the data used in this analysis, particularly state assessments, may be readily and publicly available at the school level, AIR offers an equity-focused perspective to better understand district and school performance using student-level data. We focus on groups of students who have not historically received the same opportunities as other students due to their race/ethnicity, social class, language, ability, and other characteristics, including other subgroups identified by DCSD.

Collection of Novel Data

AIR will also collect novel data by conducting a series of tailored surveys, interviews, and focus groups with students, families, staff, and district leadership. We will design these data collection efforts to provide a more vivid and nuanced understanding of the factors that support or undermine equitable opportunities and outcomes for diverse DCSD community members than what is possible through existing data alone.

We will develop three separate online surveys to assess experiences of (a) students, (b) staff members, and (c) parents/caregivers in relation to each of the relevant key areas of interest. Across these surveys, questions will cover similar topics but be tailored to the perspectives of the target audience. Surveys will be designed to efficiently generate additional quantitative data that will allow us to understand equity supports and barriers for diverse community members beyond what is examined through document review. Surveys will take 10–15 minutes to complete and will be provided in English and Spanish as well as any other common languages within the district to reach as many members of the DCSD community as possible. AIR will work with the DCSD executive director for equity and community engagement to create a robust and culturally responsive recruitment strategy to ensure high levels of participation from diverse stakeholders, including those who stand to benefit most from an equity audit (i.e., those who experience marginalization due to race/ethnicity, social class, language, ability, and other factors identified by DCSD). The culturally responsive recruitment strategy will also draw from research-based strategies for survey design and administration to maximize response rates. We will also work with DCSD to identify efficient mechanisms for gathering parental consent for students and for administering the online surveys to populations of interest.

We will design a series of in-person focus groups and interviews to better understand equity issues that emerge in the quantitative data. The focus groups will be led by experienced facilitators and constructed to provide a neutral and supportive space for stakeholders to share their experiences. We propose two student focus groups (one middle school and one high school), two parent/caregiver focus groups (including one Spanish-language focus group), one staff focus groups, and one district leadership focus group. Each focus group will include five to eight members of the target community. Informed by methodological convention, this

participation limit means that there will be certain segments of the DCSD community that are not represented in the focus groups. However, it also is important to recognize that one person cannot represent an entire group (e.g., race/ethnicity, nation of origin, gender), and thus, focus groups are most productive when they include participants with similar experiences. To ensure that focus groups result in high-quality and nuanced discussions, AIR will work with the steering committee to identify the desired composition and key constituencies to reach via focus groups (e.g., students with individualized education programs [IEPs], parents/caregivers of English language learner students, bilingual education teachers/staff). AIR will also work with the steering committee to ensure that focus groups are accessible and inclusive (e.g., provide language translation services, offer multiple times and modalities for participation).

Finally, AIR will work with the steering committee to identify key community members (e.g., district leaders, representatives of district organizations, parents of children with IEPs) to participate in interviews that will provide a more in-depth understanding of particular experiences, systems, and processes related to equity. AIR will conduct up to eight 1-hour interviews. All adult participants will provide informed consent to participate in focus groups and interviews. With parental consent, student focus group participants will provide assent for participation in focus groups.

In Exhibit 2, we provide examples of the data sources and analyses that could be leveraged to answer the guiding questions articulated in DCSD's solicitation for an equity audit. This crosswalk illustrates the kinds of data that AIR believes can offer valuable insights into the district's questions. We emphasize again, however, the critical importance of understanding and responding to DCSD's needs and priorities. We will refine the proposed data sources and analyses through collaboration with DCSD during the planning stage. Equity-focused analyses will explore opportunities, experiences, and outcomes among key subgroups of students, disaggregating data in terms of student race/ethnicity, gender, socioeconomic status, disability, English-language proficiency, immigration status, and other attributes or experiences that AIR and DCSD collaboratively identify during the planning stage and/or data collection process.

Integrative Data Analysis

AIR's experienced researchers will code, analyze, and integrate the administrative, survey, focus group, interview, and document data collected in partnership with DCSD. Analyses will use multiple equity indicators to provide comprehensive and detailed answers for each of the guiding questions. For quantitative data (e.g., administrative and survey data), AIR analysts will employ a combination of descriptive (e.g., frequencies, means, distributions) and inferential (e.g., chi-square, linear/logistic regression, analysis of variance, multilevel modeling) analyses to examine equity of opportunity, experience, and outcomes according to key demographic variables along which educational inequities typically manifest (e.g., race/ethnicity, gender, socioeconomic status, disability, English-language proficiency, immigration status). These quantitative analyses will provide clear estimates of the extent to which disproportionalities exist between and within schools, which will enhance DCSD stakeholders' ability to interpret findings and consider their root causes.

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Exhibit 2. Crosswalk of Guiding Questions, Data Collection, and Data Analysis

Critical questions	Example data	Example analyses
Instructional and programmatic equity To what degree: • Do systems ensure that every student has access to effective and quality culturally responsive learning environments and curriculum? • Do all students have equitable access to high quality educators, rigorous academic programming, social emotional learning and mental health support that meet their diverse needs? • Have systems effectively served to close the achievement gap between the diverse demographic student groups served by the district?	**Existing data** • Curriculum and instruction overview • Enrollment, graduation, retention, remediation, transfer, and exit data • State report cards and assessment data • Disciplinary referrals • Staffing data (e.g., teacher experience, retention, mobility) • School and district extracurricular and co-curricular programming **Novel data** • Focus groups, interviews, and surveys of teachers/staff, students, parents/caregivers, and district leadership regarding instructional and programmatic experiences	**Quantitative** Equity-focused analysis of instructional and programmatic elements, including the following: • Placement and performance in special education, bilingual education, gifted and talented programs, and advanced courses • Disciplinary policies, procedures, and outcomes • Access to experienced teachers **Qualitative** • Equity-focused document review of curriculum and instruction policy and implementation to examine the use of culturally responsive instructional practices and asset-based/growth-oriented assessments • Key-theme analyses regarding access to and quality of programming (e.g., technology); cultural responsivity of instruction (e.g., emerging bilingual program supports and outcomes); disciplinary processes and outcomes; access to and quality of academic, social-emotional, and mental health supports (e.g., special education processes, supports, and outcomes, multitiered systems of support)
Equitable organizational leadership To what degree: • Are district leadership structures, policies, procedures, and practices, inclusive to the diverse needs of students and families? • Does the district implement	**Existing data** • Student handbook(s) • Staff handbook(s) • Discipline policies/codes of conduct • *Core Beliefs*	**Quantitative** Equity-focused analysis of survey responses regarding fairness, inclusivity, and cultural responsivity of district policies, procedures, and practices (e.g., internal and external communication practices)

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Critical questions	Example data	Example analyses
sustainable practices to ensure that equity frameworks are woven into its organizational fabric?	**Novel data** • Focus groups, interviews, and surveys of teachers/staff, students, parents/caregivers, and district leadership regarding perceptions of existing and desired structures, policies, procedures, and practices to promote equity	**Qualitative** • Equity-focused document review of district-wide structures, policies, procedures, and practices (e.g., master schedule design, fidelity of implementation of district programs and initiatives, supervision of instruction and performance) • Key-theme analyses of teacher/staff, student, parent/caregiver, and district leadership perceptions of the adequacy and impact of existing structures, policies, procedures, and practices (e.g., decision-making processes, institutional biases, access to district resources for bilingual students)
Equitable resource distribution To what degree: • Does the district allocate resources to ensure equitable opportunities for student support? • Does the district ensure equitable resource distribution for facilities and programming	**Existing data** • School-level fiscal data • Budget allocations for key initiatives reflected in the *Core Beliefs* **Novel data** • Focus groups, interviews, and surveys of teachers/staff, students, parents/caregivers, and district leadership regarding access to necessary supports for academic, social-emotional, and mental health needs	**Quantitative** Equity-focused analysis of school- and district-level fiscal data for the following: • Educational programming (e.g., special education, bilingual education, gifted and talented programs, honors/AP courses) • Instructional supports • Extracurricular activities • Social-emotional and mental health supports • Staff-related policies and practices (e.g., staffing models, hiring practices and assignments, employee retention, leadership and faculty experience, compensation, promotion) • Facilities, equipment, technology, and other resources **Qualitative** Key-theme analyses regarding access and barriers to necessary supports

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Critical questions	Example data	Example analyses
Equitable collaboration and support for parents, families, and community To what degree: • Are students and families engaged in the educational process? • Do the conditions, systems, and structures allow parents to have an opportunity to be involved? • Does the district engage systems and practices to engage families from historically marginalized backgrounds? • Has the district been responsive to student, parent, and community needs and perspectives?	**Existing data** • Documentation of family and community engagement strategies at the district and school levels (e.g., parent and family learning opportunities and workspaces) • Names, dates, and attendance for community-focused school and district events and organizations • Title I, Part A family engagement requirements **Novel data** • Focus groups, interviews, and surveys of teachers/staff, students, parents/caregivers, and district leadership regarding equitable engagement, participation, and sense of belonging among diverse students, families, and community members	**Quantitative** Equity-focused analysis of survey responses regarding the following: • Student, family, and community-member voice, including involvement in decision-making processes • Frequency, topic, and quality of teacher/caregiver communication • Participation in school and district events and organizations **Qualitative** • Equity-focused document review • Key-theme analyses regarding successes and barriers to equitable student, family, and community engagement as well as a sense of belonging and voice among diverse students, families, and community members
Equitable professional learning and growth To what degree: • Do district employees understand the concept of equity and inclusion? • Does the district educate employees on equity and inclusion and have a process for planning, monitoring and evaluating the implementation of the learning? • Does the district offer professional learning opportunities in equity and inclusion for all stakeholders? • Does the district have systems for archiving professional learning	**Existing data** • Names, dates, and attendance for school and district professional learning opportunities • Materials from equity- and inclusion-focused professional learning opportunities **Novel data** • Focus groups, interviews, and surveys of teachers/staff and district leadership regarding opportunities to learn about, implement, and receive feedback on practices that advance equity and inclusion	**Quantitative** • Availability and attendance at equity- and inclusion-focused professional learning opportunities (e.g., professional learning employee access) • Equity-focused analysis of survey responses regarding understanding and use of equity- and inclusion-focused practices (e.g., administrator and faculty evaluation summary data) **Qualitative** • Equity-focused document review (e.g., professional learning plans and expectations) • Key-theme analyses regarding availability and effectiveness of equity- and inclusion-focused

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Critical questions	Example data	Example analyses
opportunities for use when onboarding new employees or providing refreshers for current personnel?		professional learning opportunities and desired support to enhance understanding and efficacy in implementing equity- and inclusion-focused practices and policies (e.g., schoolwide professional learning support)
Equitable School Climate To what degree: • Do district policies and practices support equitable school climate? • Does the district have systems and processes in place to support students in the area of diversity, equity and inclusion?	**Existing data** • School climate surveys • Student handbook(s) • Staff handbook **Novel data** • Focus groups, interviews, and surveys of teachers/staff and district leadership regarding school climate	**Quantitative** • Equity-focused analysis of survey responses regarding school climate, welcoming and positive school culture, and student mental health supports • Disciplinary outcomes (e.g., disciplinary referrals and associated actions, alternative education assignments) **Qualitative** • Equity-focused document review (e.g., restorative practices, alternative education assignments) • Key-theme analyses regarding the impact of district policies on staff, student, and family experiences of belonging, support, inclusion, and equity within schools (e.g., culturally responsive behavioral expectations, social-emotional learning experiences and supports)

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We will support and expand quantitative analyses using two key types of qualitative analysis. First, we will conduct strategic document reviews to assess the extent to which existing structures, policies, and practices promote equity (e.g., guidance for student and employee behavior, evaluation of student learning, mechanisms for engaging families). The strategic document review will be based on preliminary qualitative and quantitative findings. When possible, we will integrate these qualitative analyses with quantitative analyses to examine the extent to which existing programs and policies contribute to (in)equitable outcomes for students, staff, and parents/caregivers. These analyses will identify existing strengths and areas for improvement in district and school policies related to equity. Second, we will conduct key-theme analyses of focus groups and interviews to gain a more nuanced understanding of diverse stakeholders' experiences of equity across each of the relevant focal areas as well as the likely causes of and solutions to existing inequities.

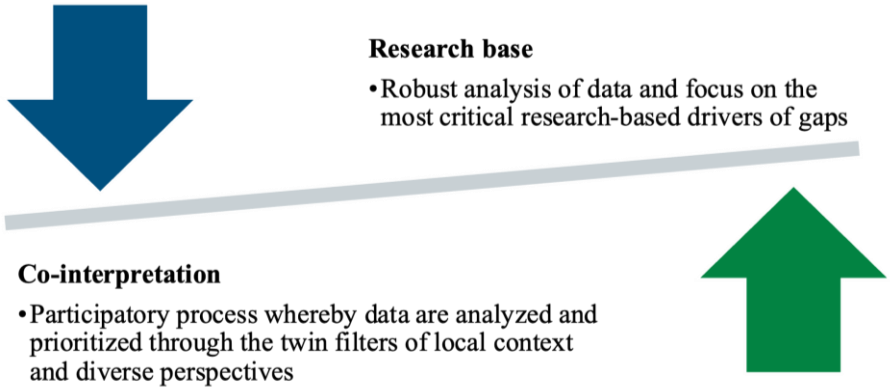
Equitable Engagement of the DCSD Community

Throughout data collection and analysis, AIR will elevate the voices of diverse DCSD community members, striving for representation across key demographics, including race, ethnicity, language/language learner status, immigration/citizenship status, socioeconomic status, gender identity, age, sexual orientation, religion, disability, and the other socio-culturally significant factors identified in Stage 1. We will take particular care when engaging community members from groups that historically have been disenfranchised and that may therefore experience a diminished sense of inclusion, belonging, access, and support within DCSD. All engagement strategies and data instruments will be rooted in the strong foundation of cultural and linguistic competence in which all AIR staff receive training. AIR's Culturally and Linguistically Appropriate Standards for Projects, Research, and Operations provide guiding principles for effectively integrating cultural and linguistic competence into all aspects of our work internally and with clients and their stakeholders. One notable example of how we plan to apply these principles in DCSD's equity audit is by using translation services to ensure that all community members can participate in surveys, focus groups, and interviews in the language most comfortable to them. Moreover, the diverse team that AIR has assembled to lead this work will bolster the success of this equity audit by drawing on its members' different personal and professional experiences to connect with the diversity of community members DCSD wishes to engage.

Stage 3: Co-Interpretation and Root Cause Analysis

AIR believes that involving people who understand the context and represent diverse voices in the system, organization, or community is important for the credibility of an EAAP. Moreover, AIR's experience in local involvement strengthens the decisions and actions that emerge from this process. This core value is manifest from the start with our collaborative approach to planning the EAAP based on the guiding questions, creating community-focused messaging to ensure transparency and inclusivity, and collectively establishing a timeline and deliverables. We carry this value through Stage 3 using a proprietary collaborative data review process that involves AIR and DCSD stakeholders' co-interpretation of the equity audit data. As shown in Exhibit 3, this process balances a rigorous research base with participatory analysis and interpretation of data.

Exhibit 3. Balancing a Rigorous Research Base With Co-Interpretation



The best available evidence suggests that changes in educational contexts are most effective when driven by the people who are closest to enacting them and that a shared commitment and responsibility for improving outcomes often emerges from working together (Bocala et al., 2013; Goddard et al., 2017; Kegan & Wagner, 2006; Knapp et al., 2010). AIR's co-interpretation process fosters local ownership and establishes the foundation for a locally driven team approach to future implementation efforts. By synthesizing best practices from research on collaborative evaluation and by building trust, ownership, and capacity, this process results in effective and united action. Co-interpretation has proven particularly effective when developing insights into contentious and often-sensitive data while generating plans for improving even the most difficult issues of equity. Since the early 2000s, AIR has used co-interpretation in diverse settings and demonstrated success in projects that require the utmost sensitivity and trust. The co-interpretation method we propose will yield a promising strategic pathway for advancing equity in DCSD.

AIR will coordinate with the steering committee to bring together stakeholders of various levels of involvement in the DCSD community—such as Board members, district administrators, teachers, parents, high school students, and community partners—who the district considers critical to its efforts. AIR will guide stakeholders in a review of the quantitative and qualitative data assembled during the data collection and analysis stage using informative, accessible, and professional data summaries. Through a thoughtfully facilitated process over 2 days, co-interpretation participants will work in small groups and read the data summaries to identify the findings they believe to be most critical to the EAAP's guiding questions, uncover and document the root causes of those findings, and use consensus building and collective interpretation to determine and prioritize areas for action and support.

Stage 4: Reporting on Findings and Delivery of Equity Action Plan

Following co-interpretation, AIR will submit both a final report of the equity audit findings and an equity action plan. The final report will describe (a) the district context and background, (b) the key findings from the EAAP regarding the six focal areas, (c) the results of our collaborative co-interpretation and root cause analysis, and (d) a summary of the district's greatest strengths and challenges identified during of the review. The equity action plan will integrate the community-developed strategies for addressing the key findings across all six areas of the equity

audit with research-based recommendations for short- and long-term improvement. The plan will focus on embedding equity-focused practices throughout the district's systems, practices, and policies to remedy existing inequities and pave a path for equitable experiences going forward, and the plan will include metrics to monitor progress and goal attainment (see Appendix B for examples). This systemic approach will mitigate the potential for biased discretionary actions and decisions that adversely affect students' educational outcomes. Importantly, the plan will identify key indicators to allow for the continual monitoring of equity-related outcomes. We will consider the district's administrative, budgetary, and other contexts to ensure that the plan is sustainable and effective in driving change toward the district's short- and long-term goals. In collaboration with the steering committee, AIR will also facilitate a community forum to solicit community input on the plan. We will integrate this feedback into a final version of the plan and then collaborate with the steering committee to disseminate the final report and plan among stakeholders, ensuring that we honor the contributions of the community members who make this assessment possible through their support and participation.

Collaborative Project Planning

AIR is committed to an applied research approach that is based on both deep collaboration with our partners and their stakeholders as well as consistent communication throughout the life cycle of projects. Our inclusive and transparent approach to project management aims to promote buy-in and ensure that the EAAP reflects the best thinking of all stakeholders while also remaining grounded in research regarding effective practices and policies. To this end, our proposed team (see Project Team section below) includes a project director who is committed to ensuring that AIR addresses DCSD's needs in a timely, high-quality manner.

In the initial planning for the EAAP (Stage 1), AIR will hold regular working meetings with the steering committee to accomplish four objectives: (a) refinement of guiding questions for the EAAP; (b) refinement of a timeline for the work, including existing DCSD structures, to facilitate efficient data collection; (c) creation of a communications plan that includes monthly meetings, with updates as needed; and (d) establishment of a steering committee to lead the EAAP in partnership with AIR. Throughout the course of the EAAP (Stages 1 and 2), AIR will hold regular working meetings with the steering committee. These meetings will provide an important avenue for AIR to keep DCSD up to date on project activities and deliverables and to solicit DCSD's input on emerging opportunities, challenges, and next steps. In Stage 3, AIR will use data summaries to facilitate a collaborative root cause analysis with the DCSD administration, the steering committee, and a group of DCSD stakeholders. In Stage 4, AIR will communicate EAAP findings in a presentation and final report and deliver a community-informed equity action plan to the department's strategic planning team and school board that leverages research-based strategies for advancing equity in the key areas identified during Stage 3.

Timeline for Deliverables

The EAAP process that we propose will result in a series of reports and resources that will help form the foundation for the equity strategies that DCSD will implement after the review. We believe that reporting throughout the review process, rather than at the end, provides a meaningful opportunity for client engagement and informs the direction of future project activities because each report highlights different strengths, points to different concerns, and

sparks conversations about emerging solutions. We consider the key data collection and convenings that inform reports to be deliverables because the reports and resources would not be possible without them. Exhibit 4 shows the deliverables that AIR will submit to DCSD across the stages of the EAAP.

Stage 1 (planning) will October 2024. AIR and DCSD will establish the EAAP steering committee, finalize the guiding questions for the EAAP, agree on the timeline and deliverables (including leveraging DCSD mechanisms and relationships to adhere to the agreed-on timeline and deliverables), and develop a communications plan.

Stage 2 (data collection and analysis) will begin simultaneously. Throughout November and early December 2024, AIR will collaborate with the DCSD data team to coordinate the collection of existing administrative data and collaborate with the steering committee to collect relevant documents for review (e.g., past equity work, student and staff handbooks, discipline policies). During this time, AIR will also work with the steering committee to develop a timeline for collecting survey, focus group, and interview data. We anticipate that staff and student surveys will be administered during the first 2 weeks of January through DCSD mechanisms. To ensure sufficient time to maximize response rates, parent/caregiver surveys will be conducted over an extended period, from early-December to mid-February. Focus groups will be conducted in early April. Given the large amount of administrative, survey, focus group, and interview data, the data cleaning, coding, and analyses will continue through mid-May.

Stage 3 (co-interpretation and root cause analysis) processes will be undertaken in late May 2025 in preparation for the final equity action plan.

In **Stage 4 (reporting on findings and delivery of equity action plan)**, we will host a community forum to collect community-based feedback and deliver a final report and the equity action plan no later than June 30, 2025.

For more details on each stage and deliverable, please see the Overview of Equity audit and Action Plan Process section.

Exhibit 4. Deliverables for Each Equity audit Stage

Stages and deliverables		Months							
	Oct 24	Nov 24	Dec 24	Jan 25	Feb 25	Mar 25	Apr 25	May 25	Jun 25
Collaborative project planning • Working meetings with DCSD administration and EAAP steering committee	£	£	£	£	£	£	£	£	£
Stage 1: Planning (October 2024)									

Stages and deliverables		Months							
	Oct 24	Nov 24	Dec 24	Jan 25	Feb 25	Mar 25	Apr 25	May 25	Jun 25
• Establishment of EAAP steering committee • Guiding questions • Timeline and deliverables • Communications plan	£	£							
Stage 2: Data collection and analysis (March–April 2024)									
• Status reports on data collection and analysis	£	£	£	£	£	£	£		
Stage 3: Co-interpretation and root cause analysis (May 2024)									
• Co-interpretation and root cause analysis • Summary report on co-interpretation								£	
Stage 4: Reporting on findings and delivery of equity action plan (June 2024)									
• EAAP presentation to DCSD steering committee and stakeholders (background, goals, data sources and methods, analysis, key findings, research-based strategies, and best practices) • Written final report of key findings and root causes of inequities uncovered through EAAP • Community forum for equity action plan • Written equity action plan that includes priorities, measurable outcomes, and short- and long-term goals for advancing equity									£

Note. EAAP = equity audit and action plan; DCSD = DeKalb County School District

Work Experience

EAAP Experience

AIR brings exemplary knowledge and understanding to conducting EAAPs and has worked extensively with districts and schools of all sizes and demographics in urban, suburban, and rural settings. In the following paragraphs, we describe several recent examples of our experience working with districts facing issues similar to DCSD's, including districts in Texas and others of a similar size and demographic composition (e.g., with large populations of Latino/Latina students and/or students from socioeconomically disadvantaged backgrounds). In addition to these examples, our EAAP work has included conducting comprehensive school needs assessments, adapting established data collection protocols to promote equity, and grounding equity work in a set of quality indicators.

Equity Work With School Districts

Rock Island-Milan School District 41 Equity Audit (February 2023–June 2024)

AIR partnered with Rock Island-Milan School District 41 to conduct an equity audit that included equity-focused analyses of (a) student achievement, discipline, intervention supports, and school climate data; (b) workforce diversity, professional development, and classroom curricula; (c) family and community engagement practices; and (d) school-level fiscal data. Similar to the process AIR is proposing for DCSD's EAAP, the partnership with this district leverages a collaborative approach to identifying key questions, timelines, procedures, and deliverables, including co-interpretation (AIR's proprietary collaboration process) and a root cause analysis. The process will culminate in both written and oral reports of findings as well as evidence-based recommendations tailored to the district context.

Relevance to EAAP: Collaborative equity audit; collection and analysis of administrative, focus group, and document data; co-interpretation; root cause analysis

Colorado Springs School District 11: Districtwide Equity Audit (2020–2022)

Colorado Springs School District 11 contracted with AIR to conduct a full-scale equity audit, provide follow-up implementation planning and monitoring, and support the creation of a district equity framework. Through data collection and focus groups, AIR gathered information on equity-focused student achievement gaps, disproportionalities in assignments, and resource allocation, among other data. The data were the basis for analysis and discussion during which AIR led the district and its various stakeholders through the same co-interpretation process that we have proposed for the DCSD's EAAP. At the end of co-interpretation, the district arrived at key priorities and actionable next steps that were used to guide their implementation planning. AIR provided technical assistance for monitoring and scale-up activities throughout the following year.

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Relevance to EAAP: Collaborative equity audit; collection and analysis of administrative, focus group, and document data; co-interpretation; root cause analysis; strategic planning and implementation of equity policies and practices

Evaluation of Los Angeles Unified School District's Student Equity Needs Index (2020–2021)

AIR was commissioned by the Los Angeles Unified School District (LAUSD) to perform an evaluation of the Student Equity Needs Index, a tool for LAUSD to understand the needs of its students and schools based on academic- and community-based indicators. Using a mixed methods design, the evaluation investigated how index funding is provided to schools, the processes by which schools determine how these funds are used, schools' strategic use of this funding to support programming, the resources and support provided by the district to assist schools in their planning and budgeting, and the degree to which the allocation of funding is associated with student outcomes such as academic achievement. The district used the findings to develop resources to support principal investment of funding for the Student Equity Needs Index.

Relevance to EAAP: Equity-focused assessment; mixed methods research design; equity-focused strategic planning

Widefield School District 3: Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion Consultant (2020–2021)

Widefield School District 3 contracted with AIR to conduct an equity audit to examine its systemic and structural makeup and provide technical assistance for implementing next steps following the audit. The audit comprised five phases that align closely with our proposed approach for DCSD's EAAP: planning, data collection and analysis, collaborative data review, findings and strategy development, and implementation planning. During data collection, AIR gathered information from documents and stakeholder focus groups to analyze equity in areas such as district demographics, program assignments, access to effective teachers, and resource allocation. Through co-interpretation, AIR led district stakeholders in reviewing the data and identifying priorities for addressing equity-related gaps in the district. Based on these priorities, AIR crafted evidence-based strategies to support the implementation of the next phase of the equity audit work.

Relevance to EAAP: Collaborative equity audit; collection and analysis of administrative, focus group, and document data; co-interpretation; root cause analysis; equity-focused strategic planning

Jamesville-DeWitt Central School District: Curriculum Audit (2020)

The New York University Metropolitan Center for Research on Equity and the Transformation of Schools partnered with the Jamesville-DeWitt Central School District in an audit to identify gaps connected to cultural responsiveness in the curriculum. The audit process brought together diverse district- and school-level stakeholders (e.g., leaders, teachers, families) to conduct the curriculum review and build their capacity. Jointly, the center and the district reviewed and scored the latter's curriculum to establish a baseline using the center's proprietary Culturally Responsive Curriculum Scorecard, which assesses cultural responsiveness in curricula focusing

on the representation of diverse authors, characters, social identities, and cultures and on social justice. AIR provided technical assistance to build district- and school-leader capacity to work alongside center facilitators to co-lead subsequent curriculum review sessions as well as identify and train emerging leaders to sustain the process.

Relevance to EAAP: Curriculum-focused equity audit, collaborative meaning making of equity-related data, equity capacity building, development of metrics for monitoring equity, equity-focused technical assistance

Equity Work With Majority-Minority Communities

Houston Independent School District: Special Education Program Review (2017–2018)

The Houston Independent School District (HISD) contracted with AIR to conduct an independent, third-party special education program review. AIR conducted the review over a 10-month period and provided an assessment of HISD's strengths and areas in need of improvement with respect to its special education program, as well as recommendations for HISD to consider for improving services for students with disabilities in the district. AIR gathered data from multiple sources, including (a) extant data on student performance, special education identification and placement, and staffing; (b) documents related to HISD infrastructure, strategic planning, guidance on policies and procedures, professional development offerings, and documentation of parent feedback and concerns; (c) IEPs for a randomly selected, representative sample of 300 students with disabilities; (d) an AIR-administered survey of all school staff; (e) an AIR-administered survey of all parents; (f) interviews and focus groups with district leaders; and (g) interviews and focus groups with staff at a randomly selected, representative sample of 27 schools. As we propose with the DCSD EAAP, AIR presented final findings and recommendations in a written report and an oral presentation to the HISD board of education and subsequently provided support to the district for strategic planning to address these findings.

Relevance to EAAP: Equity-focused assessment, equity-focused strategic planning and implementation assistance

K–12 Adequacy Cost Study for California (2017–2018)

AIR conducted a study as part of the Stanford University Getting Down to Facts project to examine the cost of educating California's students using the professional judgment approach. As part of this study, AIR convened panels of expert educators in Northern and Southern California. The panels of expert educators identified the resources required to meet California's educational goals in schools that varied by schooling level, student poverty, share of English learners, and school size. Using the resources specified, AIR researchers calculated the cost per student in prototypical schools and extrapolated these costs to determine that of providing an adequate education for all of California's students. Underlying the calculations of adequacy were administrative data on school enrollments and demographics, educational spending, teacher salaries, and other types of administrative data. Relevant to the DCSD EAAP, AIR conducted a fiscal analysis to calculate the costs of providing equitable educational opportunities by collecting and analyzing large amounts of data.

Relevance to EAAP: Equity-focused assessment, fiscal analysis, resource allocation

Evaluation of Nevada K–12 Funding System (2007–2008)

AIR performed a comprehensive evaluation of the Nevada state school finance system, and the evaluation was used to inform policy debate as well as precipitate key funding reforms. The main study deliverables relevant to the current proposed study included (a) an in-depth overview of the current Nevada Plan for School Finance, (b) the development of an inventory of state finance systems showing how states are addressing the additional costs of serving students with specific needs and other cost factors, (c) an analysis comparing patterns of actual spending across districts within all states across the country, and (d) a set of recommendations to improve Nevada's existing school funding model and incorporate best practices for addressing student needs and the challenges of delivering education in smaller rural, remote districts. As we propose with the DCSD EAAP, AIR collected and analyzed administrative data (e.g., fiscal, student demographics) for the purpose of identifying disparities in educational opportunities that could be improved through funding reforms in the school finance system.

Relevance to EAAP: Equity-focused assessment, fiscal analysis, resource allocation

K–12 Adequacy Cost Study for New Mexico (2007–2008)

AIR was commissioned by the New Mexico Legislature to conduct a comprehensive study of the state's public schools funding formula. The evaluation included analyses to determine the cost of a sufficient education for all public school students in New Mexico, including English learners, low-income students, and students receiving special education services. AIR sought public and policymaker input in defining the goals for New Mexico public schools and selected six panels representing the diversity of urban, suburban, small-town, and rural-remote districts to specify the resources necessary to fulfill New Mexico's educational sufficiency goals. The study team used the variations in resource specifications associated with school size and pupil needs to estimate the differential cost of achieving sufficiency. AIR presented recommendations for funding increases to support the academic achievement and outcomes for all public school students in rural-remote and urban areas.

Relevance to EAAP: Equity-focused assessment; community engagement, fiscal analysis, resource allocation, equity-focused strategic planning

Equity Work With Education Agencies

Regional Education Laboratory Midwest (2022–Present)

Through Regional Educational Laboratory (REL) Midwest—serving the states of Illinois, Indiana, Iowa, Michigan, Minnesota, Ohio, and Wisconsin—AIR conducts technical assistance, research, and dissemination activities to support state and local education leaders in using data to improve outcomes for students and teachers. With REL Midwest 2022, AIR is focused on improving student outcomes and acting as change agents in the educational system by (a) working deeply on high-leverage problems of practice, (b) exploring and testing solutions, (c) using logic models that outline our understanding of the necessary inputs and activities to reach expected outcomes, and (d) measuring progress on outcomes to adjust inputs and activities when necessary. Our approach focuses on connecting local, regional, and state agency staff to

develop and test local innovations that improve school and classroom practice and thereby improve student outcomes. Our scope of work is situated in our partners' renewed commitments to social justice, especially for students furthest from opportunity. State and district priorities are currently focused on diversifying the teacher workforce, creating safe and supportive schools, improving postsecondary outcomes through work-based learning, supporting school leaders in the use of data to monitor school performance, and improving instruction in literacy and mathematics. Across rural, suburban, and urban locales, Midwest districts also are focused on increasing diversity, equity, and inclusion—a theme that runs through all identified priorities.

Relevance to EAAP: Equity-focused assessments, training, coaching, strategic planning, and implementation assistance

Center for Education Equity, Mid-Atlantic Equity Consortium (2017–Present)

AIR is a subcontractor for the Center for Education Equity at the Mid-Atlantic Equity Consortium, one of four regional equity assistance centers funded by the U.S. Department of Education. Such centers lead education improvement projects and provide equity training and assistance to state education agencies, local education agencies, and schools across the country. Topic areas include civil rights laws, school and district diversity, access to high-quality and culturally competent administrators and educators, positive school climate, comprehensive wraparound services, and the engagement of families and communities in school improvement. Projects conducted through the center include a webinar focused on sharing practical examples and best practices from successful models of advancing college readiness, implementation of continuous improvement models to build schools' and districts' capacity for change, creation of resources to facilitate community engagement, and webinars focused on increasing teacher and leader diversity.

Relevance to EAAP: Equity-focused training, coaching, strategic planning, and policy/practice implementation

Illinois Empower (2018–2022)

AIR staff provided districts with leadership and teacher support in areas identified through previous needs assessments, an AIR-facilitated needs assessment, and/or the current work in the districts. Services included strategic coaching regarding intentional data reviews, continuous school/district improvement practices, district leadership team development, school leadership team development, instructional coaching, leadership coaching, curriculum and instruction, data analysis, professional learning communities, and social-emotional learning. As districts made progress toward meeting their foundational system needs, AIR coaches worked with district leaders to assess additional system support needs, including equitable frameworks, English language learner programs, special education programs, and multi-tiered support systems.

Relevance to EAAP: Needs assessment; strategic coaching and technical assistance; development and utilization of equity frameworks

Massachusetts Targeted Site Visits (2019–2021)

AIR conducted Targeted Site Visits (TSVs) in low performing schools in Massachusetts to provide schools, districts, and the Massachusetts Department of Elementary and Secondary Education (DESE) with formative information on the school turnaround process. TSVs relied on data collected from principal interviews, instructional staff surveys, and classroom observations to produce a report that provided ratings on the Turnaround Practices and Indicators that DESE determined led to successful turnaround. Drawing upon information from principal interviews, instructional staff surveys, and classroom observations, AIR staff rated the school using a rubric for the Turnaround Practices and Indicators. The reports were shared with school and district leaders and DESE staff to provide information on the school improvement process and to inform technical support efforts.

Relevance to EAAP: Onsite and online data collection; formative feedback; coaching and technical assistance

Study of New Hampshire School Funding (2020)

AIR conducted an evaluation of the equity and adequacy of school funding in New Hampshire for the state's legislatively authorized Commission to Study School Funding. As part of the study, AIR (a) produced a series of briefs that described national policy regarding school finance and the school finance systems of several comparison states, (b) reviewed analytical methods for evaluating the educational equity and adequacy of school funding systems and wrote briefs to describe these methods, (c) conducted analyses of the equity of resource distribution to describe the relationships between funding and student needs in the current system as well as variations in local tax rates across districts, (d) examined relationships between student needs and student outcomes across districts, (e) estimated cost-function models to identify how resources should be distributed to provide all students with an equal opportunity to achieve outcome goals, and (f) developed a simulation tool to project funding across districts based on different scenarios.

Relevance to EAAP: Equity-focused financial analysis; equity-focused strategic planning

Addressing Discipline Disproportionalities in Minnesota (2017–2019)

The Minnesota Department of Human Rights identified 43 districts that have high out-of-school suspension rates for Black and American Indian students compared to White students as well as high discipline rates for students with disabilities. Building on previous work, AIR, through the Midwest Comprehensive Center, provided content expertise and thought partnership to the Minnesota Department of Education in its efforts to decrease disproportionalities in suspension and expulsion.

Relevance to EAAP: Equity-focused strategic planning

Reducing School Suspensions and Expulsions in Michigan (2013–2016)

With support from AIR's Great Lakes Comprehensive Center, funded by the U.S. Department of Education, the Michigan Department of Education formed the Michigan School Discipline Task Force to address inequities in the proportion of Black students who were suspended or subjected to exclusionary discipline practices. Our project team reviewed and analyzed state and national suspension and expulsion data, researched suspension and expulsion policies in other states, and

connected the task force with restorative justice and social-emotional learning experts. Through facilitation and planning, our experts supported the state department in drafting and revising discipline policies, thereby enabling education leaders to make informed decisions and identify clear action steps. The process led to revisions of the state's *Model Code of Student Conduct*, which was supported by an online toolkit that provided guidance to all Michigan schools on creating cultural change and addressing behavioral concerns using nonexclusionary methods.

Relevance to EAAP: Equity-focused assessment, equity-focused strategic planning and implementation assistance

Sample Equity Audits and Equity Action Plans

In Appendix B, we provide three examples of final reports from the equity audits and equity action plans we have conducted in other districts. Equity audit work is highly sensitive and requires a great deal of trust between clients, their stakeholders, and AIR. Due to our commitment to maintain client confidentiality, district names have been redacted. However, our client references can speak to AIR's approach and efficacy in conducting equity audits, including assessments in large urban districts and districts with demographic compositions similar to those of DCSD.

- The first example ([REDACTED] Equity Audit) is a report from an equity audit in which we used administrative data, financial data, focus groups, and document review to examine organizational and instructional drivers of equity. Key factors included racial, ethnic, and socioeconomic segregation; student access to effective teachers and leaders; school climate; school funding; professional learning opportunities for teachers; use of culturally responsive practices; programmatic engagement, including discipline, special education, gifted and talented programs, English learner programming; and access to rigorous learning opportunities. The report includes a summary of key findings that emerged from co-interpretation and a summary of next steps based on these findings.
- The second example ([REDACTED] District Wide Equity Audit) is a strategic equity action plan based on an equity audit AIR conducted. The action plan includes a summary of key findings that emerged from co-interpretation and the identified root causes of these findings. Key findings centered on access to effective and well-paid teachers; access to teachers who reflect students' racial groups; assignment to special education services, gifted and talented programs, and discipline referrals; teacher bias; and segregation. The proposed strategies for closing equity gaps integrate community insights with evidence-based practices and include references that can be consulted for further information.
- The third example ([REDACTED] School District Equity Audit) is also a strategic equity action plan based on an equity audit AIR conducted. Like the second example, it includes a summary of community-identified key-findings and root causes. In this case, community-centered and evidence-based strategies were proposed to address equity issues concerning teacher diversity, access to academic support, culturally responsive instruction, and racial bias. Strategies include a mixture of short-term solutions, such as providing professional development for teachers to learn about culturally responsive instructional strategies, and long-term solutions, such as the development of a plan for diversifying the teacher workforce and revising the discipline process.

Use or disclosure of data contained on this sheet is subject to the restriction on the cover of this proposal.

Client References

Please find the three requested client references in Exhibit 5.

Exhibit 5. Client Reference Information

Client references	Contact information and description of services
Client Reference 1: Rock Island-Milan School District 41	**Contact:** Dr. Kathy Ruggeberg, Assistant Superintendent, Teaching and Learning **Contact information:** 309-581-2166 | kathy.ruggeberg@rimsd41.org **Description of services:** AIR is partnering with Rock Island-Milan School District 41 on a 9-month equity audit focused on four core areas: (a) student achievement, discipline, and school climate; (b) workforce diversity, professional development, and classroom instruction; (c) family and community engagement; and (d) school-level spending.
Client Reference 2: Colorado Springs School District 11	**Contact:** David Khaliqi, Chief of Strategy and Data Acquisition **Contact information:** 719-520-2347 | david.khaliqi@d11.org **Description of services:** AIR conducted a 12-month, full-scale equity audit with Colorado Springs School District 11, which included gathering information on (a) equity-focused student achievement gaps, (b) disproportionalities in assignments, and (c) resource allocation. Following the equity audit, AIR provided follow-up implementation-planning and-monitoring support, which led to the creation of a district equity framework.
Client Reference 3: Akron Public Schools	**Contact:** Dr. Carla L. Chapman, Chief Diversity Officer **Contact information:** 330-761-3297 | cchapman@apslearns.org **Description of services:** AIR, through REL Midwest, is working with partners in Akron Public Schools to develop, test, and refine an approach to addressing inequitable school discipline policies. This approach brings together school community members during one semester to identify potential sources of disparate discipline referrals. Informed by data from across the school district, the team of school leaders will discuss equity gaps, explore solutions, and develop a plan to assess policy changes.

Pricing Structure

AIR has made every effort to allocate adequate budget resources to conduct high-quality tasks and activities that are reasonable in relation to the objectives, design, and potential significance of the proposed project. For the period of performance for Stages 1 through 4 of Ocober 1, 2024 to June 30, 2024, we propose a total fixed-price budget of **$313,429.**

The proposed budget is designed around ongoing collaborative project planning and the four sequential stages of the project (Stages 1 through Stage 4). Ongoing collaborative project planning costs account for 10% of the total budget, and planning and organization (Stage 1) costs account for 15% of the budget; the remaining 75% of the project's budget is allocated to data collection and analysis efforts, co-interpretation activities, and reporting on findings and delivery of the Equity Action Plan. AIR will request written permission from DCSD prior to incurring any fees or expenses above those included in the foregoing cost estimate. Any additional work

beyond the scope of work proposed will be negotiated at the time of request. A summary of budget per stage is listed in Exhibit 6.

The proposed budget includes all resources and expenses needed for AIR personnel to complete the required tasks and deliverables across each of the stages. The staffing configuration proposed for this project reflects the required level of staff necessary to perform the project tasks as outlined in the stages, including time for undertaking AIR's quality review and editing processes.

Exhibit 6

Comprehensive Equity Audit	Total Lump Sum Cost
Lump sum cost to complete **Phases 1-3** (**Planning and Preparation, Data Collection, and Data Analysis and Interpretation)** in accordance with the scope of work as stated in Part III of this RFP.	$179265
Lump sum cost to complete **Phases 4-5 (Reporting and Recommendations and Developing the Equity Policy)** in accordance with the scope of work as stated in Part III of this RFP.	$134,164
Total	$313, 429

Proposed Payment Schedule

AIR proposes a quarterly payment schedule for Phases 1 through 5 as articulated in Exhibit 7. AIR understands that this schedule is subject to change based on final negotiations with DCSD.

Exhibit 7. Payment Schedule

Invoice No.	Timing	Invoice amount
1	Dec 29, 2024	$104,476.33
2	Mar 30, 2025	$104,476.33
3	June 30, 2025	$104,476.33
Total for all invoices		**$313,429**

Payment Terms

AIR's standard payment terms are net 30 days from receipt of a valid and accurate invoice. Invoices will be billed following the completion of each task or milestone. Notwithstanding any budgetary information provided herein, payment for services will be provided on a firm fixed-price basis. AIR's proposal is contingent on the negotiation of mutually agreeable terms and conditions, and AIR shall not be bound by the terms and conditions of any preprinted purchase orders.

Banking Information

To ensure security of client payments and increase timeliness of deposits, AIR's preferred method of payment is direct electronic deposit via EFT/ACH. AIR's general accounting staff at GeneralAccountingTeam@air.org are responsible for receipt of client payments. They will complete client forms required for direct deposit payments via EFT/ACH and send them directly to the client's designated payments office via secure transmission.

Payments also may be mailed to AIR's lockbox at the following address:

American Institutes for Research
P.O. Box 28126
New York, NY 10087-8126

Business Identification Numbers

TIN: 25-0965219

DUNS: 04-173-3197

Authorized Negotiators

Carmen Fermin, senior director of business development, 202-403-6152, AIRproposals@air.org
Kate Haaf, director of contracts, 443-259-5220, AIRproposals@air.org

Joseph Wagner, Jr., vice president, contracts and procurement, 202-403-5000, AIRproposals@air.org

Validity

This offer is good for 365 days from the date of submission. AIR reserves the right to review its submitted pricing to determine additional period(s) necessary for extension of the offered pricing or to revise its price quote after the expiration of 30 days or any subsequent offered validity period(s).

The budget is for estimation purposes and is not a guaranteed price for services. AIR's proposal is predicated on current information from the client about the project requirements and AIR's technical approach and assumptions to fulfill these requirements. Actual costs may change once the scope of work is negotiated or finalized. AIR reserves the right to negotiate final scope of work and price. Any contract award that results from this proposal is subject to negotiations of the final price and will be based on mutually agreed-to terms and conditions between the parties.

Project Team

AIR has assembled a qualified team to lead the EAAP. Team members have extensive experience with equity audits, strategic equity consulting, and working with diverse school districts. They also bring a variety of lived experiences to the work that will help AIR connect with and understand a variety of DCSD community members.

Charrise Hollingsworth, PhD, our proposed **Project Director**, will oversee development of focus group and interview protocols, recruitment of participants, and analysis of qualitative data with administrative and survey data. Dr. Hollingsworth is a researcher in the Youth, Family, and Community Development program area at AIR and a member of the equity audit community of practice. Her current work focuses on youth workforce development, advancing equitable outcomes in K–12 education, promoting social-emotional wellness for students and teachers, and supporting AIR's cross-disciplinary place-based initiatives. Dr. Hollingsworth's interdisciplinary training in community psychology focuses on ecological approaches to social and community change, improving adolescent outcomes into adulthood, and participatory action research. As a former middle school educator, she has more than 10 years of experience designing instructional trainings for schools, state agencies, and community-based organizations. Prior to AIR, Dr. Hollingsworth served as the first director of diversity, equity, and inclusion in the office of North Carolina Governor Roy Cooper, where she monitored diversity, equity, and inclusion efforts across cabinet agencies. She also provided technical assistance to the governor's equity-related task forces focused on educator diversity, racial equity in the criminal justice system, and COVID-19 recovery efforts. Dr. Hollingsworth has a BA in public policy studies from Duke University; an MSEd in education, culture, and society from the University of Pennsylvania; and a PhD in community research and action from Vanderbilt University.

Melissa Chavarria, our proposed **Communications Director,** will oversee communications with the DCSD community, including scheduling interviews, focus groups, the community forum, and any other community-engagement activities. She is a research associate in the Youth, Family, and Community Development program area at AIR. She focuses on providing project management and qualitative research for small- and large-scale projects that focus on meeting youth academic and social needs and advancing equity. Chavarria has worked in both practice and in research for the past 6 years, during which she has led research efforts and programming for integrating postsecondary pathway opportunities in marginalized communities. She has served as project manager and qualitative support for previous AIR work in Texas. Additionally, she serves as the project manager for a scaling evaluation project funded by an Education Innovation and Research grant from the U.S Department of Education. In 2019, she received her master's degree in public affairs from The University of Texas Rio Grande Valley.

Orrin Murray, PhD, our proposed **Quality Assurance Reviewer**, will provide quality assurance services throughout the equity audit and action plan process, ensuring that the project activities and products meet AIR's rigorous quality standards and effectively meet DCSD's needs. As a principal researcher at AIR, Dr. Murray's primary responsibilities include overseeing the research-practice partnership for REL Midwest, all of which focus on dimensions of equity and culturally responsive education. He is also a co-principal investigator on a project evaluating an American History and Civics Education–National Activities grant program. He also leads

work at AIR in the areas of equity and culturally responsive practices, data visualization, design thinking, learning technologies, and the use of machine learning to support improvements in practice. Dr. Murray holds a PhD from the University of Michigan.

References

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Brown, K. M. (2010). Schools of excellence and equity? Using equity audits as a tool to expose a flawed system of recognition. *International Journal of Education Policy and Leadership*, *5*(5), 1–12. https://journals.sfu.ca/ijepl/index.php/ijepl/article/view/206

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Tieg, N., & Nilsen, T. (2022). Profiles of instructional quality in primary and secondary education: Patterns, predictors, and relations to student achievement and motivation in science. *Studies in Educational Evaluation*, *74*(4), 1–17. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/360504039_Profiles_of_instructional_quality_in_primary_and_secondary_education_Patterns_predictors_and_relations_to_student_achievement_and_motivation_in_science

Appendices

Appendix A. Résumés

Laura Brady, PhD A–2

Melissa Chavarria, MPA A–8

Holly Williams, PhD A–10

Ajay Srikanth, PhD A–14

Charrise Hollingsworth, PhD A–16

Orrin T. Murray, PhD A–19

Laura Brady, PhD

Proposed Role: Project Director

AIR

EXPERTISE

- District-wide equity audits and strategic planning
- Survey design, implementation, and analysis in educational settings
- Cultural and psychological barriers to educational equity
- Supporting educators in creating culture change in K–12 classrooms, schools, and districts
- Research-practice partnerships to advance educational equity

EDUCATION

- PhD, Social and Personality Psychology, University of Washington, 2016
- Quantitative Psychology Minor
- Diversity Science Specialization
- MS, Social and Personality Psychology, University of Washington, 2013
- BA, Psychology, DePaul University, 2011

EXPERIENCE

Dr. Brady has more than 10 years of experience conducting mixed-methods research in laboratory, online, and field settings. Her work focuses on identifying systemic, cultural, and psychological barriers to educational equity and using empirically derived strategies to foster equitable outcomes in K–12 and higher education. She has designed, implemented, and evaluated equity-focused professional development trainings for K–12 educators, served as research director in a district-wide research-practice partnership, and directed the development, implementation, and assessment of a pipeline program for Indigenous students in social and cultural psychology.

Present Position

Senior Researcher, American Institutes for Research (AIR) (2022–Present)

Dr. Brady leads and contributes to research, evaluation, and technical assistance focused on advancing equity in K–12 education. She leverages expertise in diverse qualitative and quantitative methodologies to design, implement, and assess strategies for advancing equitable outcomes for students, teachers, families, and other stakeholders. Dr. Brady leads proposal development; provides training and supervision for project teams; builds and maintains relationships with clients, partners, and other stakeholders; develops reports, briefs, infographics, and other dissemination materials; and collaborates with partners and stakeholders to make evidence-based decisions about programs, policies, and practices designed to advance equity.

Selected Professional Experience

Qualitative Lead, Rock Island-Milan School District (RIMSD) 41 Equity Audit (2023–Present)

AIR is partnering with RIMSD 41 to conduct an equity audit focused on (1) student achievement, discipline, intervention supports, and school climate data; (2) workforce diversity, professional development, and classroom curricula; (3) family and community engagement practices; and (4) school-level spending. This partnership uses a collaborative approach to identify key questions, timelines, procedures, and deliverables, including a root cause analysis. The process will culminate in both written and oral reports of findings as well as evidence-based recommendations tailored to the district context. As the qualitative lead, Dr. Brady oversees the development of guiding questions; design and implementation of focus group protocols and document review; and qualitative coding, analysis, and reporting.

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Equity Consultant, Massachusetts Center for School and District Partnership Progress Monitoring (CSDP), Research & Evaluation System Development (2023–Present)

AIR is partnering with the Massachusetts CSDP to create a new school monitoring structure for Massachusetts based on the Coherence Guidebook developed by the Massachusetts Department of Elementary and Secondary Education. This system will assist Massachusetts state staff in identifying areas in which each school is most in need of support and provide them with a way to efficiently and effectively review data to pinpoint both strengths and areas for growth. The system includes a rubric and data map to illuminate inequities in the quality of educational opportunities provided to English learners, students from racially minoritized backgrounds, students from lower-income households, and other historically marginalized groups. Dr. Brady serves as an equity consultant, ensuring that equity principles are embedded within the assessment rubric, educator surveys, data map, and school reports.

Co-Principal Investigator, Building a Pipeline for Indigenous Equity in Social and Cultural Psychology, University of Michigan (2021–2022)

This pipeline program trains the next generation of Indigenous social and cultural psychologists via an 8-week residential research internship accompanied by year-round professional development, community building, and mentoring activities. In the 1st year of a 3-year pilot, the program successfully recruited 10 Indigenous undergraduate interns from across the United States and paired each intern with a graduate student mentor who supported them in developing and presenting an independent research project at university and national conferences. The program is supported by the Doris Duke Charitable Foundation as well as the College of Literature, Science, and the Arts; the Provost's Office; and the Department of Psychology at the University of Michigan. As the co-principal investigator, Dr. Brady oversaw program development, budgeting, implementation, and assessment. She hired and supervised a PhD-level program director, curriculum development assistant, events coordinator, and research coordinator and managed a budget of $2.5 million.

Co-Principal Investigator, Creating Cultural Change in Educational Systems: Can Leadership Level Inclusion Training Reduce Achievement Gaps? University of Washington/Michigan (2018–2022)

This NSF-funded research-practice partnership leveraged a train-the-trainer professional development model to help school leaders create inclusive school cultures using an evidence-based model of culture change. The intervention successfully enhanced educators' culturally inclusive beliefs, which in turn increased educators' use of culturally inclusive practices, thereby enhancing students' psychosocial and academic outcomes. Moreover, the project led to identification of culturally inclusive practices that successfully reduced racial achievement gaps. Dr. Brady oversaw the design, implementation, and assessment of the districtwide intervention; facilitated communication between the research and practitioner teams; provided ongoing support for educators; hired and supervised junior team members, including a postdoctoral research fellow, four graduate students, and three research coordinators; managed a $584,000 budget; and communicated findings to partners, educational researchers, and lay audiences.

Co-Principal Investigator, Moving Beyond Changing Mindsets: Creating a Culture of Growth in Schools, University of Washington/Michigan (2016–2021)

With funding from the Raikes Foundation and the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation, Dr. Brady served as the project director on an interdisciplinary team that designed, implemented, and

evaluated professional development curricula to help K–12 teachers integrate principles of growth mindset and inclusion in their everyday teaching practices. Curricula were iterated upon over the course of 3 years, during which approximately 150 educators and 2,500 students in the Seattle metropolitan area participated in the program. All curricula were successful in promoting positive beliefs about inclusion and growth mindset among teachers. Additionally, teachers' use of evidence-based growth mindset practices fostered more positive attitudes toward school and greater identity safety among students. Dr. Brady led teacher recruitment and CE distribution; designed instructional and technical assistance materials; provided ongoing support for educators; oversaw collection, cleaning, storage, coding, and analysis of longitudinal quantitative and qualitative data from teachers and students; hired and supervised junior team members, including a postdoctoral research fellow, two graduate students, and two research coordinators; managed a budget of approximately $2.5 million; and communicated findings to teacher participants, researchers, and lay audiences.

Employment History

2022–Present	Senior Researcher, American Institutes for Research
2021–2022	Executive Director, Research for Indigenous Social Action and Equity Center, University of Michigan
2019–2022	Associate Research Scientist, University of Michigan Psychology Department
2018–2019	Research Scientist, University of Washington Psychology Department
2016–2018	Research Associate, University of Washington Psychology Department

Awards and Honors

Hunt Fellowship, University of Washington, 2016
Graduate Student Service Award, University of Washington, 2015
Graduate Research Fellowship, National Science Foundation, 2012

Professional Affiliations

American Educational Research Association
Society for Personality and Social Psychology
Society for the Psychological Study of Social Issues

Selected Publications

Brady, L., Fryberg, S., Markus, H. R., Griffiths, C., Yang, J., Rodriguez, P., & Mannen-Martinez, L. (2021). Teaching means talking about socially sensitive topics: How to set the stage for conversations that benefit all students. *Education Week, 40*(23), https://www.edweek.org/teaching-learning/opinion-difficult-conversations-and-identity-safety/2021/02

Murphy, M., Fryberg, S., Brady, L., Canning, E., & Hecht, C. (2021). Global Mindset Initiative Paper 1: Growth mindset cultures and teacher practices. Available at SSRN: https://ssrn.com/abstract=3911594

Kaiser, C. R., Dover, T. L., Small, P., Xia, G., Brady, L. M., & Major, B. (2021). Diversity Initiatives and White Americans' Perceptions of Racial Victimhood. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*. https://doi.org/10.1177/01461672211030391

Dai, J. D.*, Lopez, J. J., Brady, L. M., Eason, A. E., & Fryberg, S. A. (2021). Erasing and dehumanizing Natives to protect positive national identity: The Native mascot example. *Social and Personality Psychology Compass,* e12632. https://doi.org/10.1111/spc3.12632

Dai, J. D.*, Eason, A. E., Brady, L. M., & Fryberg, S. A. (2021). #NotAllWhites: Liberal-Leaning White Americans Racially Disidentify and Increase Support for Racial Equity. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*. https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167220987988

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Brady, L. M., & Eason, A. E. (2020). Making the invisible visible: Transformative research and social action. *Wiley Special Issue*, https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/toc/10.1111/(ISSN)1530-2415.making-the-Invisible-visible

Fryberg, S. A., Eason, A. E., Brady, L. M.[+], Jessop, N., & Lopez, J. J. (2020). Unpacking the mascot debate: Native American identification predicts opposition to Native Mascots. *Social Psychological and Personality Science, 12*(1), 3–13. https://doi.org/10.1177/1948550619898556

Brady, L. M., Higheagle Strong, Z., & Fryberg, S. A. (2020). *The mismeasure of Native American students: Using data disaggregation to promote identity safety*. In R. T. Teranishi, B. M. D. Ngyuen, C. M. Alcantar, & E. R. Curammeng (Eds.), *Measuring race: Why disaggregating data matters for addressing educational inequality* (pp. 131–153). Teachers College Press.

Brady, L. M., Fryberg, S. A., & Shoda, Y. (2019). The importance of cultural context: Expanding interpretive power in psychological science. *APS Observer, 32*(3), https://www.psychologicalscience.org/observer/the-importance-of-cultural-context

Brady, L. M., Fryberg, S. A., & Shoda, Y. (2018). Expanding the interpretive power of psychological science by attending to culture. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, November 2018, 115*(45)*, 11406–11413. https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1803526115

Bang, M., Brady, L. M., Fryberg, S. A., & Murphy, M. C. (2018, November 20). The value of "peer teaching" [Blog post in Education Week]. Retrieved from https://blogs.edweek.org/teachers/classroom_qa_with_larry_ferlazzo/2018/11/response_the_value_of_peer_teaching.html

Eason, A. E., Brady, L. M., & Fryberg, S. A. (2018). Reclaiming representations and interrupting the cycle of bias against Native Americans. *Daedalus. 147*(2), 70–81. https://www.amacad.org/sites/default/files/publication/downloads/008_Eason-Brady-Fryberg-pp070-081.pdf

Brady, L. M., Germano, A. L., & Fryberg, S. A. (2017). Leveraging cultural differences to promote educational equality. *Current Opinion in Psychology, 18*, 79–83. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2017.08.003

Brady, L. M., Kaiser, C. R., & Major, B. (2015). It's fair for us: Diversity structures cause women to legitimize discrimination. *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 57*, 100–110. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jesp.2014.11.010

*Kaiser, C. R., Major, B., Jurcevic, I., Dover, T., Brady, L. M., & Shapiro, J. (2013). Presumed fair: Ironic effects of organizational diversity structures. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 104*(3), 504–519. https://doi.apa.org/doi/10.1037/a0030838

**Winner of the Gordon Allport Intergroup Relations Prize, Society for the Psychological Study of Social Issues.*

Selected Presentations

Wang, C., Brady, L., Fryberg, S., Yang, Y., Griffiths, C. M., Markus, H., Rodriguez, P., & Parker, D. (2023, April). *District-Wide Cultures of Inclusion Enhance Teachers' Beliefs and Practices and Students' Psychosocial and Academic Outcomes*. Presentation accepted at the American Educational Research Association, Chicago, IL, United States.

Morman, K., Brady, L., Wang, C., Murphy, M. C., Bang, M., & Fryberg, S. (2023, April). *Creating Identity Safe Classrooms: A Cultural Educational Psychology Approach to Teacher Interventions*. Presentation accepted at the American Educational Research Association Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL, United States.

Brady, L. M. (2023, Feb. 2). *Utilizing the Culture Cycle to Create Inclusive Schools: A Research-Practice Partnership Approach*. Invited talk. University of Michigan RacismLab.

Brady, L. M., & Griffiths, C., M., (2022, May). *Dismantling educators' psychological and cultural barriers: A pathway to equity.* Chaired symposium at Society for Research in Child Development Topical Meeting: Construction of the 'Other': Development, Consequences, and Applied Implications of Prejudice and Discrimination, Rio Grande, Puerto Rico, United States.

Brady, L. M., Eason, A. E., & Fryberg, S. A. (2022, April). *Maintaining educational inequality: Fixed mindsets and system legitimization*. Presented at American Educational Research Association, San Diego, CA, United States.

Brady, L. M., Keels, M., Lindsay, C., Scherer, E., & Easton, J. (2021, February). *Supporting the socioemotional well-being of students through transitions*. Presented at Society for Research on Educational Effectiveness Virtual Conference.

Brady, L. M., Griffiths, C., M., Markus, H. R., Parker, D., Rodriguez, P., & Fryberg, S. A. (2020, October) *Effects of inclusive practices and pedagogies on student-teacher relationships: Evidence from a school-level intervention*. Presented at Western Psychological Association Virtual Conference.

Brady, L. M., Fryberg, S. A., Griffiths, C. M., & Markus, H. R. (2019, May). *Building culture change educational interventions*. Psychological Interventions in Educational Settings, Stanford University, Palo Alto, CA, United States.

Brady, L. M., Fryberg, S. A., & Shoda, Y. (2019, April). *Building interpretive power in psychological science*. Stanford University Social Lab, Palo Alto, CA, United States.

Melissa Chavarria, MPA

Proposed role: Deputy Project Director

EXPERTISE

- Qualitative data collection in English and Spanish, including interviews and focus groups in-person, by phone, or surveys
- Qualitative analysis in English and Spanish and reporting in English
- Qualitative project management, implementation, and evaluation

EDUCATION

- MPA (Summa Cum Laude), University of Texas Rio Grande Valley, 2019
- BA, Sociology and Political Science, St. Edwards University, 2017

EXPERIENCE

Five years of experience in program implementation and evaluation programs using qualitative approaches

LANGUAGES

- Spanish–Native speaker

Present Position

Research Associate, American Institutes for Research (AIR) (2021–Present)

Assist and lead in multiple qualitative projects by contributing both content and technical knowledge to project teams and activities. Has worked across multiple fields, including youth, family, and community development, CTE, and adult education. Provides technical assistance, including data analysis, content creation, video coding, and coordinating tasks. Ability to work with mentor, Airtable, NVivo, Google Suites and capable of quickly learning new software. Developed an implementation, fidelity, and quality for a SEL program. Management responsibilities include tracking project timelines and deliverables, coordinating communication and recruitment with participants, establishing a communication protocol for participating districts, and maintaining communication with clients.

Selected Professional Experience

Project Manager for the Scaling thinkSRSD Study (Department of Education Grant) (2022–Present)

Manage deliverable completion across the impact, implementation, and cost study evaluation of the study. Provide support in outreach and communication for 32 districts with a total of 60 schools. Coordinate incentive distribution and tracking using Airtable database. Use advanced Airtable data management knowledge to facilitate troubleshooting with external participants and internal leads. Accountable for monitoring progress and preparing client reports.

Project Manager for the Austin Independent School District (AISD) Equity Initiative (2022–2023)

Managed the progress of the project and ensured that deliverables are met in a timely manner. Provided meeting support and coordinated with task leads on providing summary reports to the client. Additionally, provided support in the qualitative portion of the study by conducting English and Spanish focus groups with students and parents of who were part of the AISD community. Reviewed protocols, consent forms, and translated all documents into Spanish. Conducted a document review of materials that will be used for an equity evaluation of the AISD.

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Co-Chair for AIR VIVA Employee Resource Group (2022–Present)

Co-lead AIR VIVA employee engagement efforts and provide educational events that highlight the importance of the Latinx community within AIR and beyond. Provide continuous support in DEI initiatives and co-facilitate AIR VIVA events such as Hispanic Heritage Month, biweekly Cafecito chats, and general membership meetings.

Co-Qualitative Lead for the CCEE-RII Evaluation Grant (2023–Present)

Co-lead formative evaluation qualitative data collection for the CCEE Reading Instruction and Intervention grant. Develop and review protocol materials, conduct focus groups/interviews and analysis.

Qualitative Research Associate for the Educate Texas: College and Career Readiness Models (CCRSM) Evaluation (2023–Present)

Conduct focus groups and interviews with school staff, high school graduates, and institutions of higher education leaders for a formative evaluation of the CCRSM models in Texas. Assist with a inductive and deductive analysis process and co-write themed memos.

Qualitative Lead for the Project Elevate Formative Evaluation (2023)

Led qualitative data collection, analyzed data, and developed a written memo for client. Reviewed protocol and submitted to Institutional Review Board for approval. Facilitated four interviews involving one instructor and three students in a university-level program aimed at certifying students with TESOL and other certifications. Developed codebook for analysis and used NVivo to develop themes that would support the improvement of the courses involved in the program. Created and programmed consent forms and communication plans. Presented to client the preliminary findings of the qualitative data and supported the writing of the analysis produced by a survey source.

Qualitative Data Collection Coordinator for the Communities in Schools Reengagement Evaluation (2021–2022)

Conducted and coordinated data collection and analyzed data for six case studies. Developed a Delphi survey for reengagement affiliates and coordinated survey communication and data collection. Created and programmed consent forms, protocols, and communication plans. Provide support with client meetings by tracking meeting notes and following up with action items.

Employment History

2021–Present	Research Associate, AIR
2018–2021	Career Integration Manager, KIPP Texas Public Schools-Austin
2017–2018	Urban Education Fellow, Great Oaks Charter School-AmeriCorps
2016–2017	Office Assistant, Foster LLP Immigration Law Firm
2017	Prison Advocate Intern, Texas Association Against Sexual Assault
2016	Account Management Intern, Career Plug
2015	Client Intake Intern, Equal Justice Center
2014–2016	Student Career Advisor/Peer Academic Coach, St. Edward's University Academic Support Programs

Holly Williams, PhD

Proposed Role: Quantitative Data Lead

EXPERTISE

- Supporting and leading teams that carry out comprehensive research and evaluation studies with a focus on education systems.
- Utilizing qualitative and quantitative data to create information to support improved outcomes for students at the local, state, and national levels.

EDUCATION

- PhD, Quantitative Methods in Educational Psychology, The University of Texas at Austin, 1994
- MA, Clinical Psychology, Southern Methodist University, 1987
- BS, Psychology, Southern Methodist University, 1984

EXPERIENCE

Over 20 years of experience leading teams in planning, designing, and conducting evaluations in a K–12 setting.

Present Position

Senior Researcher, American Institutes for Research (AIR) (2022–Present)

As Senior Researcher in the Education Systems and Policy program at AIR, Dr. Williams' primary responsibilities are supporting and leading teams that carry out comprehensive research and evaluation studies with a focus on education systems, utilizing qualitative and quantitative data to support improved outcomes for students at the local, state, and national levels. She has extensive experience in research and evaluation at the local education agency level and led a highly skilled team of researchers in the Department of Research and Evaluation in the Austin Independent School District (AISD).

Dr. Williams served as cochair of the Research Subcommittee for The University of Texas at Austin/AISD Research Collaborative. She was a member of the Council of the Great City Schools, Directors of Research and Evaluation Group, and was a founding member of the Central Texas Educational Research Consortium.

Supports and leads teams that carry out comprehensive research and evaluation studies with a focus on education systems, utilizing qualitative and quantitative data to create information for programmatic improvements and improved outcomes for students at the local, state, and national levels. Acts as the director of the College and Carrier Readiness and Success Models Evaluation (CCRSM EVAL) project. Acts as the Reviewer Support Manager for the Evidence Support Center (ESC). Is the lead on a Regional Educational Laboratory (REL) Midwest coaching project with the Illinois State Board of Education (ISBE) Office of Research and Evaluation (ORE). Acts as an REL Southwest Texas partnership codirector.

Selected Professional Experience

Lead, REL Southwest Texas Education Agency (TEA) Tri-Agency Workforce Priorities (TTWP) Partnership, AIR (2023–Present)

Partners with staff from the College, Career, and Military Preparation Division at TEA who are working to ensure that all Texas high school students have access to high-quality career and education pathways. Supports staff within this division on the Counseling, Advising, and Student Supports team to empower Texas districts to plan, implement, and evaluate a comprehensive school counseling program that supports students to and throughout their career and education pathway. Provides support to TEA for expanding development of and assessing program implementation around high-quality tools and resources for College and Career Counseling by codeveloping evidence-based materials, tools, and resources for districts to utilize in supporting

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students in creating their individual student plans and assessing the implementation of those resources, including districts' use of individual career and academic plans.

Project Director, Evaluation of College and Career Readiness School Models Program, AIR (2022–Present)

Conducts an implementation study to examine fidelity of implementation of the College and Career Readiness School Models (CCRSM) campuses in Texas. Evaluates fidelity of implementation to the CCRSM blueprints and examines variation in implementation by campus-level factors (e.g., student and staff demographic characteristics; CCRSM type; campus concentration by student race, ethnicity, low-income status, and English learner student status) and staff background (e.g., education and experience of teachers, administrators, and counselors).

Reviewer Support Manager, Evidence Support Center (ESC), AIR (2022–Present)

Serves as the point of contact for study reviewers and strategy investigators. Hosts regular strategy investigation team meetings, monitors progress, and timelines. Attends reviewer team meetings to document questions and issues. Provides ongoing support to the entire team of reviewers and strategy investigators. Is part of the ESC leadership team.

Director, Department of Research and Evaluation, AISD (2000–2022)

Directed all district research and evaluation initiatives, including collaboratively developing the annual research agenda for the district. Led team in developing and implementing the annual plan of work which identified programs to be evaluated and services to be provided, as well as detailing the scope of work, timeline, and deliverables for each project (Publications Archive | Austin ISD). Supported team in providing formative and summative feedback for program improvement and decision-making to program managers, and other district stakeholders. Met regularly with district leadership to provide research and evaluation updates and keep leadership apprised of outcomes. Partnered with external agencies and universities; maintained the external research application process for the district to support researchers whose work in turn supported district initiatives and improved outcomes for students and staff. Hired and supported a highly skilled staff of twenty, while maintaining an extremely positive work environment. Participated as a researcher on several major district initiatives and was ultimately responsible for the quality of all departmental deliverables. Worked with the Office of Innovation and Development to develop grant proposals that supported the needs and major initiatives of the district. Developed processes and systems to create efficiencies and to streamline and improve departmental work.

Assistant Director, Department of Accountability, Student Services, and Research, AISD (1996–2000)

Led the Office of Program Evaluation. Duties included acting as a liaison to district, state, and community decisionmakers, developing annual research/evaluation agenda, hiring/supervising staff and consultants, developing innovative departmental policies and procedures, and maintaining federal, state, local evaluation budgets.

Employment History

2022–Present	Senior Researcher, AIR
2000–2022	Director, Department of Research and Evaluation, AISD
1996–2000	Assistant Director, Department of Accountability, Student Services, and Research, AISD
1994–1996	Chapter One/Title I Evaluator, Department of Accountability, Student Services, and Research, AISD
1992–1994	Educational Research Specialist II, Office of Policy Planning and Evaluation, Texas Education Agency
1990–1991	Teaching Assistant, Department of Psychology, The University of Texas at Austin
1988–1989	Psychological Services Specialist, Psychological and Social Services, Dallas Independent School District (DISD)
1987–1988	Early Childhood Assessment Specialist, Department of Special Education, DISD

Professional Credentials and Certifications

Licensed as a Psychologist, Texas State Board of Examiners of Psychologists, (1995–Present)

Professional Affiliations

American Educational Research Association
American Evaluation Association

Selected Publications

Andrews, P., Christian, C., & Williams, H. (2022). Creative Learning in Adverse Times (DRE Publication No. 21.05). Austin, TX: Austin Independent School District. Retrieved from Publications Archive | Austin ISD.

Christian, C., & Williams, H. (2021). AISD Summer Programs 2021 (DRE Publication No. 21.03). Austin, TX: Austin Independent School District. Retrieved from Publications Archive | Austin ISD.

Debaylo, M., Christian, C., Lucas, M., Archuleta, H., Minney, D., & Williams, H. (2021). Remote and In-Person Learning in AISD: Implementation, Context, and Outcomes (DRE Publication No. 20.13). Austin, TX: Austin Independent School District. Publications Archive | Austin ISD.

Williams, H. (2020). DRE Plan of Work, 2020-2021 (DRE Publication No. 20.01). Austin, TX: Austin Independent School District. Publications Archive | Austin ISD.

Williams, H. (2019). DRE Plan of Work, 2019-2020 (DRE Publication No. 19.01). Austin, TX: Austin Independent School District. Publications Archive | Austin ISD.

Hutchins, S., Debaylo, P., & Williams, H. (2018). Thinking Heuristically About Student Growth in Austin Independent School District (DRE Publication No. 17.33). Austin, TX: Austin Independent School District. Publications Archive | Austin ISD.

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Andrews, M., Hutchins, S., & Williams, H. (2018). Summary of Austin Independent School District Telecommuting Surveys (DRE Publication No. 17.09). Austin, TX: Austin Independent School District. Publications Archive | Austin ISD.

Wang, C., Christian, C., Hasty, B., Williams, H., Andrews, M., & Green-Otero, J. (2017). Creative Learning Initiative: Annual Evaluation Report 2015-2016 (DRE Publication No. 15.68). Austin, TX: Austin Independent School District. Publications | Publications Archive | Austin ISD.

Christian, C., Schmitt, L., & Williams, H. (2016). Overview of Enrollment Findings, Spring 2016 (DRE Publication No. 15.38 RB). Austin, TX: Austin Independent School District. Publications Archive | Austin ISD.

Looby, K., Lyons, A., & Williams, H. (2016). Enrollment from Fall 2015 to Fall 2106, Trends by grade level and student group (DRE Publication No. 16.07 RB). Austin, TX: Austin Independent School District. Publications Archive | Austin ISD.

Williams, H. (2011). Plan of Work, 2011-2012 (DRE Publication No. 11.01). Austin, TX: Austin Independent School District. Publications Archive | Austin ISD.

Williams, H. (1994). Confirmatory Factor Analysis vs. Common Factor Analysis with Procrustes Rotation. Doctoral dissertation, University of Texas at Austin.

Williams, H. (1987). The effect of thought vocalization on sleep latency. Master's thesis, Southern Methodist University.

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Ajay Srikanth, PhD

Proposed Role: Resource Allocation Lead

AIR

EXPERTISE

- Proficient in conducting advanced quantitative analysis using quasi-experimental techniques
- Proficient in building cost models for estimating equity and adequacy
- Have worked in multiple roles in PK–12 education, including as an analyst and as a Spanish teacher

EDUCATION

- PhD, Educational Theory, Policy, and Administration, Rutgers University, 2022
- EdM, Education Policy and Social Analysis, Teachers' College, Columbia University, 2012
- MA, Teaching- Spanish- National-Louis University, 2009
- BS, Finance and Hispanic Studies, Boston College, 2007

EXPERIENCE

Five years of experience conducting research on equity and adequacy in PK–12 school finance. Experience with NCES data sets. Additional experience with student-level data for English learners and students with IEPs for multiple school districts. Experience teaching Spanish at elementary and secondary levels and introductory education course to prospective teachers at university level.

LANGUAGES

- Spanish–Fluent

Present Position

Researcher, American Institutes for Research (AIR) (Aug 2022–Present)

Education finance researcher examining equity and adequacy in PK–12 systems and postsecondary education. Experience using large administrative data sets and quasi-experimental research designs to evaluate school funding and student outcomes. Works with state agencies to redesign funding formulas to meet the needs of students.

Selected Professional Experience

Cost Researcher, ISBE SEL Initiative, AIR; Illinois State Board of Education (June 2023–Present)

I am currently a cost researcher for the Illinois Social Emotional Learning project. In the project, I am helping to analyze the costs of implementation of professional development for social-emotional learning throughout the state.

Lead Quantitative Researcher, MNPS English Learner Plan, AIR and Metro Nashville Public Schools (Jan 2023–Present)

I am currently the lead quantitative researcher for the following two components of this project: the educator survey and the extant data analysis. For the educator survey, I helped to administer a survey of educator perceptions regarding the education of English learners and analyzed the data. For the extant data, I analyzed data on the English proficiency and achievement of English learners in the district. I also helped write sections of the Findings Memo related to these two components.

Quantitative Researcher, Delaware Adequacy Study, AIR and Delaware Department of Education (Aug 2022–June 2023)

I was one of the quantitative researchers and facilitators for the Professional Judgment Panels (PJPs). The PJPs entailed focus groups of educators from across the state to determine the costs of an adequate education. For the PJPs, I used school-level data to provide information to panelists from throughout Delaware to determine the costs of an adequate K–12 education. The panels were conducted in February and March 2023.

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Analyst, Newark Public Schools, Office of Special Education (Aug 201–Aug 2019)
I monitored and analyzed special education data for Newark Public Schools in New Jersey to determine programming for students with disabilities. I also provided technical support to Child Study Teams, monitored district compliance with state and federal regulations with respect to special education, and prepared reports on special education enrollments for the State. With respect to special education funding, I worked with the special education Medicaid initiative coordinator to ensure that the district was reimbursed for the provision of related services and also worked with the financial analyst to receive funding for extraordinary id.

Employment History

2022–Present	Researcher, AIR
2019–2021	Graduate Assistant, Rutgers University Graduate School of Education
2015–2019	Analyst, Newark Public Schools, Office of Special Education
2012–2014	Analyst, Chicago Public Schools, Office of Language and Cultural Education
2007–2010	Spanish Teacher, Chicago Public Schools

Awards and Honors

David L. Clark Scholar, University Council for Educational Administration, 2020

Professional Affiliations

American Educational Research Association
Association for Education Finance and Policy

Selected Publications

Baker, B. D., Weber, M., & Srikanth, A. (2021). Informing Federal School Finance Policy with Empirical Evidence. Journal of Education Finance, 47(1), 1–25.

Srikanth, A., Atzbi, M., Baker, B.D., & Weber, M. (2021). How States Fund Education. The Oxford Handbook of U.S. Education Law.

Baker, B. D., Srikanth, A., Green III, P. C., & Cotto, R. (2020). School funding disparities and the plight of Latinx children. Education Policy Analysis Archives, 28, 135.

Baker, B. D., Weber, M., Srikanth, A., Kim, R., & Atzbi, M. (2018). The real shame of the nation: The causes and consequences of interstate inequity in public school investments. Education Law Center. Retrieved from https://www.shankerinstitute.org/sites/default/files/The%20Real%20Shame%20of%20the%20Nation.pdf

Charrise Hollingsworth, PhD

Proposed Role: Qualitative Lead

AIR

EXPERTISE

- Community psychologist with a background in organizational and systemwide change
- Develops and facilitates adult learning experiences for professional and personal development
- Assesses diversity, equity, and inclusion strategic plans to identify and measure proximal and distal outcomes

EDUCATION

- PhD, Community Research and Action, Vanderbilt University, 2021
- MSEd, Education, Culture, and Society, University of Pennsylvania, 2014
- BA, Public Policy Studies, Duke University, 2009

EXPERIENCE

More than 10 years of experience designing instructional trainings for schools, state agencies, and community-based organizations

Present Position

Researcher, American Institutes for Research (AIR) (2022–Present)

Conducts qualitative research to assess programs and initiatives related to thriving youth and adults. Current work focuses on equity audits in school districts, state agency approaches to addressing student and staff well-being, place-based initiatives, and sociocultural approaches to support thriving populations.

Selected Professional Experience

Project Director, Community Schools Initiative Evaluation Planning, Baltimore City Public Schools (2023–Present)

Leads listening sessions for key stakeholders (e.g., community school coordinators, lead partner agencies, school principals, district leadership) to share input on to learn more about the processes key stakeholders engage in to support implementation of the community school strategy. Responsibilities include administrative project management (e.g., IRB, data governance), developing protocols for listening sessions, and supporting qualitative data analysis and report writing.

Project Director, Justice Equity Fellowship, AIR Equity Initiative (2023–Present)

Manages all aspects of a fellowship designed to advance employment opportunities in research and technical assistance positions for individuals directly impacted by the justice system. Responsibilities include leading the fellowship's learning and development activities, managing the fellowship support staff, and organizing the program evaluation process.

Task Lead, Advancing Opportunities for Adolescents, Wallace Foundation (2023–Present)

Designs and implements data retreats for 31 out-of-school time partnerships to gather real-time survey participation and reactions to preliminary interview findings with service providers. Facilitates focus groups with program partners. Develops data retreat meeting materials to guide engagement between program partners. Creates facilitation guides and train project team members.

Project Co-Director, Equity audit, Austin Independent School District (2022–2023)

Led community forum design and planning committee with local stakeholders. Codeveloped focus group protocols as an Instructional Equity researcher. Conducted student focus groups and qualitative data analysis. Contributed to report writing, facilitate co-interpretation process that

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informed root-cause analysis. Created and submitted data governance plan for IRB documentation.

Qualitative Lead, Youth Workforce Development, San Francisco Department of Children, Youth, and Families (2022–Present)

Leads the development and implementation of qualitative data collection efforts, including creating interview and focus group protocols and guidance for conducting site visits and observations. Trains support staff to conduct in-person and virtual interviews. Develops qualitative data analysis plan and reporting mechanisms.

Community Engagement Support, Evaluation and Technical Assistance of the Institute for American Policing Reform's Community Engagement and Education Pillar, AIR Equity Initiative (2022–Present)

Manages relationship with consulting partner's work to support community interactions with law enforcement. Serves as a liaison between the AIR's research and technical assistance team and consulting partners to support the creation of community participation councils, the facilitation of the councils' meetings, and the development of resources and deliverables for project events.

Research Support, Council of Chief State School Officers, AIR (2022–Present)

Provides research and policy support the Community of Practice efforts of the Council of Chief State School Officers (CCSSO) as they develop and revise statewide plans to address the social and emotional well-being of students and teachers. Contributes to the planning and execution of Community of Practice meetings, including supporting documents and content expert presentations. Assists the facilitation of individual state coaching calls to provide guidance and share best practices across the Community of Practice. Contributes to report writing and document creation.

Director of Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion, Office of North Carolina Governor Roy Cooper (2021–2022)

Monitored statewide diversity, equity, and inclusion initiatives across 10 cabinet-level agencies by identifying systemic best practices that promote equitable outcomes for all North Carolinians. Convened 15 diversity, equity, and inclusion state agency leaders to build a supportive professional learning community that fosters collaboration and networking opportunities. Guided the implementation of educational policy recommendations by leveraging the professional expertise of six members from the Department of Administration's Educational Opportunity subcommittee.

Education Policy Fellow, Office of North Carolina Governor Roy Cooper (2020–2021)

Directed stakeholder engagement with state agencies, legislators, philanthropic partners, and K–12 educators to develop an implementation plan for diversifying the educator workforce. Coordinated with the Governor's senior education policy advisor and the Office of State Budget Management to advance the Governor's $32 billion budget for North Carolina's public schools. Produced and disseminated policy briefs and press releases for external partnerships between the Governor's Office and national efforts to promote positive youth outcomes.

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Employment History

2022–Present	Researcher, American Institutes for Research (AIR)
2021–2022	Director of Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion, Office of NC Governor Roy Cooper
2020–2021	Education Policy Fellow, Office of NC Governor Roy Cooper
2014–2021	Graduate Instructor and Student, Vanderbilt University
2104–2014	Summer Policy Fellow, Children's Defense Fund
2013–2014	Program Evaluator, Netter Center for Community Partnerships
2013–2013	Summer Educational Consultant, Classroom, Inc.
2012–2013	Instructional Support Specialist, Chapel Hill-Carrboro Public Schools
2011–2012	Manager of Teacher Leadership Development, Teach For America (Eastern North Carolina)
2009–2011	Middle School Math Teacher, Miami-Dade County Public Schools

Professional Affiliations

Society for Community Research & Action
American Education Research Association
Society for Research on Adolescence
Society for Research on Child Development

Selected Publications

Cunningham-Erves, J.**,** Joosten, Y., **Hollingsworth, C.P.**, Cockroft, J.D., Murry, V.M., Lipham, L., … Miller, S.T. Implementation of a dual-track research training program. (2020). *Progress in Community Health Partnerships: Research, Education, and Action, 14*(1), 75–87. DOI: 10.1353/cpr.2020.0010.

Hollingsworth, C.P. (2018). Implementing Social Justice Curricula in Human Services Contexts. *Issues of Race & Society, 6*, 65–85.

Selected Presentations

Hollingsworth, C.P. (2020, January). *"I Have a Say, Too": Perceptions of Social Change Involvement from High School into Adulthood*. Presented at meeting of Society for Social Work and Research, Washington, DC.

Hollingsworth, C.P. (2018, April). *Exploring Social Justice Education in a Human Services Context*. Presented at meeting of Society for Research on Adolescence, Minneapolis, MN.

Bess, K., **Hollingsworth, C.P.**, and Malpert, A. (2017 June). *If you build it, will they come? Data-Use Behavior in an Out-of-School Time Program Network.* Presented at meeting of Society for Community Research and Action Biennial Meeting, Ottawa, ON, CA.

Hollingsworth, C.P., Nixon, C., Hennessy, E., Fuller, A., Mullane, C., and Shields, S. A. (2017, April). *Theory-Driven Approach to Strengthen Teaching and Learning in After-School Programming.* Presented at meeting of American Educational Research Association Annual Meeting, San Antonio, TX

Bess, K., **Hollingsworth, C.P.**, Malpert, A. (2017, April) *Cross-Institutional Organizational Learning in a Network Linking Middle Schools and After-school Program Providers.* Presented at meeting of American Educational Research Association Annual Meeting, San Antonio, TX.

Orrin T. Murray, PhD

Proposed Role: Quality Assurance Reviewer

EXPERTISE

- Experienced developing data visualizations and facilitating translation of research into practical applications
- Expertise in developing focus group and interview protocols focused on equity
- Develop tools for educators to understand and make use of culturally relevant teaching practices

EDUCATION

- PhD, Education, University of Michigan, 2006
- AM, Learning Technologies, University of Michigan, 2001
- MBA, General Management, University of Virginia, 1989
- BA, Political Science, Williams College, 1984

EXPERIENCE

More than a decade of experience developing and conducting R&D with design thinking and design-based research lens in education settings.

Present Position

Principal Researcher, American Institutes for Research (2021–Present)

Provides research and technical assistance on federal-, state-, and district-level projects with a focus on equity. Responsibilities include developing documents, tools, and protocols for use by fellow researchers and educators, contributing to planning and improvement of existing and developing projects, particularly through qualitative data analysis, and working with educators in the field to ensure fidelity of research participation and provide technical assistance to move toward greater equity.

Provides leadership for seven Regional Educational Laboratory Midwest partnerships focused on R&D efforts to craft interventions and approaches targeting high-leverage needs in participating partner districts.

Selected Professional Experience

Culturally Responsive and Restorative Practices grant, Austin Independent School District (2021–2022)

Led the external evaluation of a Culturally Responsive Restorative Practices program developed and implemented by the Austin Independent School District through an Education Innovation and Research Early Phase Grant. The study considered students attending restorative practice (RP) schools versus those in non-RP schools to determine the relationships among RP and school climate, student disciplinary referrals, and academic achievement. Implementation of the program was measured through school-level observations; teacher, administrator, and RP coordinator interviews and focus groups; and student focus groups and surveys.

District Reviews, Massachusetts Office of Elementary and Secondary Education (2021–2022)

Led the efforts to focus on indicators of equity in statewide review of districts. Participated in site visits and development of protocols to look for indicators of equity during site visits and across extant documents. Worked with research team to produce clear district-review reports.

Diversifying Teacher Workforce Project, Delaware Department of Education (2021–Present)

Provides consulting advice on the development of a data-visualization tool to highlight ongoing efforts to support the diversification of Delaware's teacher workforce.

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Director of Technology and R&D, UChicago Impact (2013–2020)

Architect and manager of a digital foundry responsible for design, creation, and maintenance of research-based social science tools. Tool set included scalable survey platforms, online and in-person curricula, digital data collection tools, data-visualization platforms for school climate, social and emotional development, and elementary literacy assessment applications.

Technical Lead, Cultivate, UChicago Impact (2016–2022)

Worked in a research-practice partnership with applied researchers from the Consortium on Chicago School Research, a collection of individual schools and three district/charter organizations to test and develop a theory on the relationship between student mindset and academic performance. Cultivate began with a focus on understanding how to help students become more effective learners and wrapped up with a focus on teachers who were cultivating relevant classroom conditions to foster student mindset development. Led an interdisciplinary coalition of software designers, applied researchers, and participating schools to develop a tool that would support the theory-testing process while ensuring that schools could productively make use of the resulting research. Principles of design thinking and design-based research drove the development process.

Project Director, To&Through, UChicago Impact (2013–2018)

Led the design and development of an online tool to improve high school graduation rates in the nation's third-largest school district. Funded primarily by private foundations in Chicago, the To&Through project focused on lowering barriers for stakeholders to make effective use of research that pointed to the most important factors leading to or impeding high school graduation. Convened and engaged diverse stakeholders (e.g., policy makers, funders, and educators), collected data from these gatherings to inform design, negotiated with core researchers who uncovered the indicators, and worked with software developers to bring the project to life. Relied on aspects of design thinking and design-based research to refine the tool prior to its formal launch. By focusing stakeholders throughout Chicago on the factors highlighted by rigorous research, the To&Through online tool is purposively public, and this transparency serves to broaden and deepen its use and impact across the city of Chicago.

Employment History

2021–Present	Principal Researcher, AIR
2013–2020	Director, UChicago Impact
2008–2013	Assistant Professor, The Pennsylvania State University
2006–2007	Postdoctoral fellow, University of Michigan
1997–1999	Account executive, Apple, Inc.
1996–1997	Product marketing manager, Eagle River Interactive, Inc.
1990–1996	Education marketing, Apple, Inc.

Selected Publications

Murray, O. (2016, December 9). *Keep it simple, schools*. US News. https://www.usnews.com/opinion/knowledge-bank/articles/2016-12-09/basic-data-infrastructure-helps-students-succeed

Murray, O. T., & Olcese, N. R. (2012). Blogging towards praxis. In P. Resta (Ed.), *Proceedings of Society for Information Technology & Teacher Education International Conference 2012* (pp. 2007–2014) in Chesapeake, VA. AACE.

Land, S., Zimmerman, H., Murray, O., Hooper, S., Sharma, P., & Mundie, J. (2011). Mobile computing: Perspectives on design, learning, and development. In M. R. Simonson (Ed.), *Proceedings of selected research paper presentations at the 2011 annual convention of the Association for Educational Communications and Technology* (pp. XX–XX) in Jacksonville, FL. http://www.aect.org/publications

Webber, D. E., & Murray, O. T. (2011). World Language Education Students Inter-continental blogging during study abroad. Proceedings of the 10th annual Worldwide Forum on Education and Culture.

Murray, O. T., & Olcese, N. R. (2011). Teaching and learning with iPads, ready or not? *TechTrends 55*, 42–48.

Murray, O., Vilberg, J., & Clausen, R. (2010). *Interactions and reflections of instructional technology coaches*. Pennsylvania Department of Education.

Clausen, R., Vilberg, J., Murray, O., Meidl, C., Sockman, B. R., Sonak, B., & Peck, K. (2011). *21st Century Teaching and Learning with Technology (21st CTL): Year 4 evaluation report*. Pennsylvania Department of Education

Peck, K., Clausen, R., Vilberg, J. Meidl, C., & Murray, O. (2009). *Classrooms for the Future: Year 3 evaluation*. Pennsylvania Department of Education.

Murray, O. T., & Zembal-Saul, C. (2008). Educate at Penn State preparing beginning teachers with powerful digital tools. *Journal of Computing in Higher Education 20*(2), 48–57.

Peck, K., Clausen, R., Vilberg, J., Stoicescu, C., & Murray, O. (2008). *School technology use and the development of 21st century skills: A report to Quaker Valley School District*.

Peck, K., Clausen, R., Vilberg, J. Meidl, C., & Murray, O. (2008). *Classrooms for the Future: Year 2 evaluation*. Pennsylvania Department of Education.

Peck, K., Clausen, R., Byers, C., Fidishun, D., Murray, O., & Stoicescu, C. (2007). *Is Classrooms for the Future changing teaching and learning in Pennsylvania schools?* Pennsylvania Department of Education.

Appendix B.
Example Equity audits and Action Plans

About the American Institutes for Research®

Established in 1946, the American Institutes for Research® (AIR®) is a nonpartisan, not-for-profit institution that conducts behavioral and social science research and delivers technical assistance both domestically and internationally in the areas of education, health, and the workforce. AIR's work is driven by its mission to generate and use rigorous evidence that contributes to a better, more equitable world. With headquarters in Arlington, Virginia, AIR has offices across the U.S. and abroad. For more information, visit AIR.ORG.

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